

VINOBA BHAVE ON SELF-RULE

— MICHAEL W. SONNLEITNER

FOREWORD

At first glance, the words of Jesus: 'A prophet is not without honour, save in his own country' are inapplicable to Vinoba Bhave. In India millions revered him as a saint, and, during the early years of the campaign for Bhoodan, the spectacle of 'the saint on the march', walking from village to village appealing for, and receiving, gifts of land for the landless, won publicity and admiration in countries throughout the world. But, as the author of this book observes, Vinoba as a thinker remains poorly understood in both East and West. This is especially true of Vinoba the political thinker, as my own experience illustrates.

When, in the early Sixties, I was seconded to teach in India, my political science colleagues there expressed surprise that I should take as my research project the Sarvodaya movement, then led by Vinoba. Belonging as they did to India's Westernised elite, they could not understand why a visiting Western scholar found the subject interesting. They were not convinced by my explanation that there was more to the Sarvodaya movement than its novel, and admittedly not overly successful, approach to solving 'the land problem': it was also engaged in elaborating a new kind of politics. Coming from England, fresh from participating in mass civil disobedience demonstrations organised by the radical wing of the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament, I was excited to find

that, in the very different Indian context, some of the then fashionable ideas of the New Left had been anticipated by Vinoba and his associates. Besides nonviolent action, these ideas included a critique of both Bolshevik Communism and Welfare State Socialism, the espousal of community action and communitarian socialism, and the notions of direct participatory democracy, 'people's power', and 'the politics of the people', as distinct from 'the politics of the State' and party politics.

My own understanding of the political ideas of Sarvodaya, as expressed in The Gentle Anarchists, was undoubtedly coloured by the ideological spectacles I brought with me to India. I was an anarchist and, like most Western anarchists, also an atheist, even anti-theist. Further, at the time when I began my research, I did not regard myself as a pacifist, since what attracted me to nonviolence was the technique of nonviolent action which does not require a commitment to non-violence as a principle and as a way of life. As I pursued my study of the Sarvodaya movement, I became aware that its ideas rested on metaphysical foundations quite different from my own. (Indeed, as a student brought up on the philosophy of logical positivism, I denied that my ideas had any metaphysical foundation as all!) But I felt that I could ignore or, at least, pass lightly over the difference. In this I was encouraged by Jayaprakash Narayan's version of Sarvodaya thought. In mediating Vinoba's ideas, 'JP', educated in Western social science, expressed them in a 'language' easily appreciated by people like myself.

Further reflection, however, has convinced me that Sarvodaya ideas, including its political ones, can be properly understood only if they are viewed within the framework of

Indian religious thought and seen as a re-interpretation of a
distinctively Indian conception of the self and the relation
of the self to society, nature and the cosmos. It is, there-
 fore, a great merit of Michael Sonnleitner's book that, in
 explicating Vinoba's idea of swaraj and his critique of rep-
 resentative democracy, he relates them to Vinoba's religious
 thought. The result is illuminating, and the book consti-
 tutes an excellent introduction to Vinoba the political think-
 er. Since the author is an American political scientist, the
 book is also a hopeful sign that Vinoba's political thought
 is beginning to be taken seriously in Western Academia.

At one point in the author's exposition, I do join issue
 with him. 'It now appears', he writes, 'that what has been
 called the "anarchism" of Vinoba Bhave might better be de-
 scribed as "anti-statism". . . .' As I see it, however, this
 is a distinction without a difference if what we have in mind
 is Western anarchism. 'Anti-statism' is a characteristic
 of such anarchism. As far as Vinoba's thought is concerned,
 perhaps neither label quite fits, but 'anti-statism' less so
 than 'anarchism'. Mindful of Vinoba's usually firm posture
 of 'non-opposition' to those who disagreed with him, I would
 say he leaned more towards 'non-statism' of the kind expressed
 by earlier communitarian socialists, such as the followers of
 Robert Owen. But only 'leaned' because, unlike the Owenites,
 Vinoba did not ignore the state. Like Gandhi, he recognised
 that the state represents 'organised violence'; and he argued
 explicitly that, as humans collectively achieve liberation,
 the state as we now understand it will be transcended; or, to
 put it more simply, the state will 'wither away'.

Since the primary purpose of attaching labels to a po-
 litical thinker ^{www.vinoba.in} is to aid our own understanding, it is not

intrinsically important which label we pin on Vinoba. But, for Western readers at least, there is some point in classifying Vinoba's political thought under the heading of 'anarchism' provided one notes the following rider. It is an indigenous Indian anarchism and not one of the varieties of Western anarchism imported into India. And I would add: if Western anarchists do not recognise Indian anarchism when they see it, this merely exposes their unconscious Eurocentric perspective.

It is a further merit of Michael Sonleitner's book that it stimulates such reflections. It is also a short book which whets the appetite for a more comprehensive study of Vinoba's political thought, and one which examines how his thought was expressed in action, not least in the controversial last years of his life which are covered in my later study of the Sarvodaya movement, Nonviolent Revolution in India. On the evidence of the present book, Michael Sonleitner is well-equipped to write such a study, and I hope that he will do so.

Geoffrey Ostergaard

University of Birmingham, England

17 November 1986

INTRODUCTION

Although he was revered throughout his native India, Vinoba Bhave, as an activist and as a thinker, remains poorly understood in the East and West alike. A brief picture of Vinoba and of the movements which made him a saint in the eyes of many of his countrypeople might thus be helpful prior to outlining my project and research approach.

Vinoba: The Man

On May 11, 1953, the cover of Time magazine was devoted to a "trusted and faithful disciple of the late Mahatma Gandhi".¹ In other articles throughout the 1950's Acharya Vinoba Bhave was variously described as a "mystic,"² a "practical saint,"³ and as "a skinny, penniless oldster with sunken cheeks, a wispy white mustache and beard".⁴ It was reported how millions spoke of him as "the new Gandhi"⁵ and how many of India's

¹"A Man on Foot," Time 61: May 11, 1953, p. 32.

²Robert Trumbull, "Holy Man Who Walks in Gandhi's Steps", New York Times Magazine, February 10, 1952, p. 13.

³George Weller, "Vinoba Bhave: India's Walking Messiah", Yale Review 42: December, 1952, p. 238.

⁴"Bhoodan & Gramdan", Time 72: December 29, 1958, pp. 20-21.

⁵A.M. Rosenthal, "The Story of a Saint," Coronet 39: January, 1956, p. 40.

leaders looked upon him as "Gandhi's moral heir."⁶

To be discussed in such terms is understandable given the background of Vinoba's life. Born into a Chitapavan Brahmin family on September 11, 1895, he was reared in a religious atmosphere to which the asceticism of his mother contributed greatly.⁷ At the age of twelve Vinoba had taken a vow of life-long chastity⁸ and by the age of twenty-one resolved to abandon his university studies in order to seek self-realisation (moksha) in the holy city of Benaras.⁹ It was in that city that Vinoba's path crossed that of Mohandas K. Gandhi.

From 1916 to Gandhi's death in 1948, Vinoba deserves to be called "the son of Gandhi"¹⁰ for such was the relationship that existed between the two men. Vinoba so revered his adopted father that he once wrote to him in a letter that "with me, nothing counts in this world except your blessing."¹¹ From Gandhi's viewpoint Vinoba was "a Bhīm—a Hercules"¹² and even his spiritual superior in many ways.¹³ In 1940 Gandhi selected Vinoba even above Jawaharalal Nehru for the honor of

⁶Weller, Yale Review, p. 244.

⁷Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1962), p. 11.

⁸Rosenthal, Coronet, p. 40.

⁹Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 13.

¹⁰"The Fifth Son," Time 58: November 26, 1951, p. 40.

¹¹"Letter to Bapu," cited by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 23.

¹²Gandhi, quoted by Arthur Koestler, "Last of the Saints," Commentary 29: February, 1960, p. 147.
www.vinoba.in

¹³See Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, pp. 23-23.

initiating the individual resistance campaign against British rule in India. All totaled, Vinoba spent five years in prison during the independence movement.¹⁴

It was only after "independence" and Gandhi's assassination that Vinoba really proceeded into the world limelight. Holding that "the land problem . . . is the main problem for the whole of Asia"¹⁵ he began to propagate the saying of Tulsidas¹⁶ that "Sampati sab Raghupati Ki hai" (all wealth, including land, belongs to God.)¹⁷ Interpreting God, in this case, to mean "society"¹⁸ Vinoba called upon the rich and poor alike to voluntarily give up land for redistribution to the most desperate in their village.

Believing that "there is no human problem but can be solved by human intelligence"¹⁹ Vinoba appealed to both the heads and the hearts of the landed. To their heads he argued that his Bhoodan (Land-Gift) movement was the only alternative to the redistribution through violence advocated by the com-

¹⁴Rosenthal, Coronet, p. 41

¹⁵Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 38.

¹⁶Tulsidas is the revered translator of the epic poem Ramayana into the vernacular. He has the God-incarnation, Ram, espouse the quoted position.

¹⁷Tulsidas, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 418.

¹⁸Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 62.

¹⁹Vinoba Bhave, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 66.
www.vinoba.in

munists.²⁰ He told them, in other words, that it was in their self-interest to part with a portion of their land since "the time will come when he who owns great possessions will be looked on as a thief."²¹

To self-interest he added an appeal to the heart which said: "it is more blessed to give than to receive."²² The spiritual attainment of the society would be enhanced, he maintained, as individuals came to realize that "God dwells in the hearts of all beings"²³ and demands service particularly with regard to the poorest. Speaking of the landed, therefore, Vinoba observed how they "should remember that I am not asking for alms but want land as a matter of right"²⁴ and how he was initiating them into the tenets of a new ideal."²⁵

The "new ideal" was represented in a word of ancient usage which had been resurrected by Gandhi: Sarvodaya. This is a Sanskrit word comprised of Sarva (all) and Udaya (rising) which may be roughly translated as meaning "the all-round well being or good of all."²⁶ Put more simply, Sarvodaya is often

²⁰In Telingana District, Hyderabad, where the movement began, some 3,000 persons had been killed by communists and rebellious poor. See "Communism v. Gandhi's 'Son,'" Time 57: June 4, 1951, p. 36.

²¹Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 190.

²²"A Man on Foot," Time, p. 32.

²³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 8

²⁴Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 71.

²⁵Ibid.

²⁶Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 17.

understood as the "common good" including "compassion for all."

While important implications of the ideal will occupy much of the body of this paper, it may be here observed that faith in such a "common good" inspired Vinoba to journey, on foot, at least 25,000 miles, village to village, between 1951 and 1960.²⁷ The appeals of Vinoba and his few coworkers, moreover, drew contributions of some eight million acres of land from over 700,000 donors during this same period.²⁸

Before entering into retirement, Vinoba witnessed a fantastic growth in a second movement initiated as a sequel to Shoodan. Gramdan, also an offspring of the Sarvodaya ideal, strikes more deeply at the "ownership complex"²⁹ by demanding surrender, by the individual, of land to the village community as a whole. Gramdan, or "village-gift," becomes the term applied to a village when at least seventy-five percent of the people owning at least fifty percent of the land sign a pledge relinquishing their private ownership.³⁰ By 1974

²⁷Koestler, Commentary, p. 141. (One writer says 35,000 miles: Kingsley Martin, "The Gandhi Way," Atlantic Monthly 206: August, 1960), p. 63.

²⁸Ibid., p. 143. (It should be noted that this is far short of Vinoba's goal of fifty million acres by this date.)

²⁹Vinoba Bhave, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957), p. 3.

³⁰Devi Prasad, "Gramdan: The Land Revolution in India," War Resistance 1969, Vols. 28-29, p. 30. (Note: this pledge was made easier in 1963 when, instead of having to relinquish use of one-sixth of one's land, one needed to part with only one-twentieth.)

there were over 100,000 Gramdan villages in India—over one-seventh of the total number of villages in the country.³¹

My Project

Given this background, it is not surprising that most analysts of Vinoba Bhave have focussed upon the relationship of the Bhoodan and Gramdan movements to the religious concepts underlying Sarvodaya as well as on the task of criticizing these movements from a pragmatic perspective.³² Curiously enough, however, almost all of these writers have failed to deal with Vinoba's conviction that "since India's accession to freedom our people have become slaves."³³ Indeed, few have even commented upon his assertion that:

The truth is that no real freedom exists today, and we shall not get it so long as we carry on with our 'representative democracy' and do not take the management of our own village affairs into our own hands.³⁴

³¹What Sarvodaya Stands For (Wardha: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1974), p. 66.

³²The following works are the best available (see the bibliography for details of publisher, etc.): The Social and Political Philosophy of Sarvodaya After Gandhi by Vishwanath Tandon, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study by Adi H. Doctor, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought by Indu Tikekar, A Great Society of Small Communities by Sugata Dasgupta, and The Gentle Anarchists by Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell.

³³Vinoba Bhave, Gramdan for Gramswaraj (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 37.

³⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 64-65. (underlines mine)
www.vinoba.in

Those who have dealt, to some extent, with Vinoba's criticisms of majority rule, party rule, the nature of power and of the nature of representation itself usually include in their analyses some mention of swaraj. Vinoba tells us that

Swaraj is a term in Vedic language. It is defined thus: Swarajya is the government of each by each, i.e., it is such a government that it will seem to each to be his own rule, or government by all, or Ramrajya (Kingdom of God.)³⁵

Even with such clear reference to the religious importance of the term "swaraj", none that I have read have sought to explain Vinoba's criticisms in the light of his religious-conceptual framework. If "real freedom," for example, has an essentially spiritual connotation I fail to see how Vinoba's attack upon representative government can be understood, let alone be dealt with fairly, outside of his framework. My present conviction that "real freedom" has such a meaning and the fact that most writers have overlooked the importance of Vinoba's religious thought upon his political position affords me an opportunity to break some new ground.

It is, accordingly, the purpose of this book to indicate the relationship of "swaraj" and "real freedom" to each other in the context of Vinoba's religious framework as well as to examine Vinoba's critique of representative democracy in the light of this framework. I intend to show how he came to assert the implicit proposition that representative democracy stifles the development of each person as a spiritual being and then to evaluate the consistency with which his prescrip-

³⁵Vinoba Bhave, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 37.
www.vinoba.in

tions for action or inaction reflect this view.

This enterprise bears the burden of several major problems. First among these is the generally unsystematic nature of almost all of Vinoba's writings. Unlike James Madison in The Federalist, No. 10, Vinoba does not present his thoughts in a manner which some enterprising Robert Dahl would find clear to analyze.³⁶ To try to systemize Vinoba, therefore, is imperative for the sake of analysis. In this context, of course, I must seek to avoid falling into the role of an apologist or a manipulative critic. My intention will be to be as "objective" as possible, even if this means including criticisms which may make some people uncomfortable who revere Vinoba's name.

A second major difficulty consists of the extreme complexity of Vinoba's thought, once one opens the floodgates into his religious framework. As it appears to me to be much more like an immense spider-web than not, I have frequently found myself at a loss to decide what to include in this short book.³⁷ Moreover, to say what is "essential" and what is merely a deduction is, in the context of a spider web, bound to result in unfair and unjustifiable oversimplification.

This leads into the last major problem which is integrally

³⁶I refer to Robert A. Dahl, A Preface to Democratic Theory (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1970), pp. 4-33.

³⁷For example, I wondered whether or not to include a discussion of the "gunas," or "natural qualities" of man. Deciding to include such a discussion required a modification in the place of svadharma (duty) in the paper since its mention must precede the rajas guna yet cannot be well understood until after karma yoga is discussed.

related to the concept of logic itself. Obviously the system of logic, including the bias of culture, which is brought to bear upon any subject profoundly affects the analysis of that subject. When Vinoba, for example, informs us that "the very idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong"³⁸ it would be easy to immediately react against him as somehow illogical. It is difficult to relate to someone who, we must remember, is proceeding forth with a different value system, a different conception of polity, and even a conception of reality which departs from those many of us normally hold.

Indeed, some of his formulations are illogical if we confine ourselves to a somewhat static conception of what logic is. In Vinoba's conception of God, for example, God both is and is becoming to the extent that God is both existent beyond humankind and humankind is becoming merged with God at the same time. In the former case there is no free will because God acts on people while in the latter case there is free will because the mind of each person can either turn away from or towards the God within. While this paragraph, itself, may be incomprehensible outside of Vinoba's framework, it is sufficient for the reader to realize that sometimes Vinoba used a dialectical form of logic which allows for a thing to both be and not be at the same time while at other times he employed a more formal logic which concludes that the ruling of one over oneself is incompatible with the ruling of others over oneself.

My approach in dealing with these problems includes: (1) remaining as conscious of them as I am able to, (2) allowing Vinoba to speak for himself as often as, through my organiza-

www.vinoba.in

³⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 2.

tion of his thought, he is able to do so and (3) confining myself largely to the areas in which he utilizes formal logic or, at least, to not utilize formal logic to criticize areas of his thinking which clearly were never meant to conform to such criteria.

Accordingly, due to points two and three above, some of my analysis may appear to be either essentially descriptive or largely arbitrary. Such may or may not be the case. My integrity here rests largely upon allowing Vinoba to analyze himself (whenever possible) and in confining the scope of the analysis so as to deal adequately with that portion of his thought having an important bearing upon his religious critique of representative democracy.

The reader will find the analysis which follows divided into three chapters: "On Swaraj," "On Democracy," and "Conclusions." In the first chapter I discuss Vinoba's Sarvodaya conceptual (religious) framework while seeking to clarify the role that swaraj plays within that framework. The philosophy of Sarvodaya, as Vinoba formulated it, "finds its justification in religion, makes its appeals in terms of Hindu moral precepts, is publicized through mythological allusions"³⁹ and may well try one's patience as its roots and implications are explored. I only ask the reader to plow through any apparently irrelevant material in the faith that its relevance will be later clear.

In the second chapter the information gained from preceding analyses sheds light upon Vinoba's opposition to external coercive rule of any kind and, particularly, his dislike of rule by representatives. Emphasis is placed upon his concern

³⁹www.vinoba.in Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches, p. 43.

for developing "niti" (moral rule) as opposed to "raj" (rule of the State). With his implicit proposition established⁴⁰, I then evaluate some of his prescriptions for action or inaction within its context.

The last chapter is meant to both draw the loose strands of analysis together as well as to capsule my impression of Vinoba's contribution. Avoiding more than a basic summary of the paper, I shall hope that the reader may consider a good, comprehensive summary to be the whole of this short book itself. Preceding the bibliography, however, I include an alphabetical reference to the meaning of all Indian terms I have used here as well as a second appendix including my summarized impressions of what Vinoba means by God, Man, Society, State, and Government.

If any justification for the enterprise is considered necessary at this point, I can only admit that both Vinoba's conceptual framework and many of the prescriptions which follow from it make a lot of sense to me. My present bias agrees with Indu Tikekar's conviction that "basically, all human problems are spiritual and they should be treated integrally."⁴¹ The commitment that I share with Vinoba of seeking to find ways of resolving human conflict through nonviolence, has also, undoubtedly, affected my decision to study him.

So it is that this project may be thought of as an intellectual exercise involving self-introspection, if nothing

⁴⁰The proposition, again, being that: Representative democracy stifles the development of each person as a spiritual being.
www.vinoba.in

⁴¹Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. xviii.

more. Although reason may not be capable of establishing faith, still it may be employed to either support it or to bring one to the point of changing it. In this sense, perhaps Vinoba's following statement might be rendered intelligible:

When blind faith is shaken, there is no harm in it. . . .

But blind unbelief should not replace blind belief. It is not as if belief alone can be blind, that it has a monopoly of blindness. Unbelief too can be blind.⁴²

In 1982 Vinoba's spirit left this world, 87 years after having been born into it. During his long life, Vinoba had come to reject unbelief even as his own spiritual journey left him with a faith which could blindly accept no truth as absolute. As we now turn to examine the religious framework that he struggled to build, let us appreciate it even if we may not fully agree with it. In the very least, we may come to understand Vinoba Bhave more fully as the relationship between his religious perspectives (with regard to swaraj) and his political views (with respect to representative democracy) is explored.

⁴²Vinoba Bhave, Talks on the Gita (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 228.

CHAPTER ONE

ON SWARAJ

In the beginning of the book, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, Vinoba Bhave informs us that

Sarvodaya means that the good of all resides in the good of one. That there could be interests of one person, which are against the interests of another is inconceivable. Similarly, there could be no interests of one community, class or country which would be against the interests of any other community, class or country. The idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong.¹

Such an assertion, which for Vinoba had the logical status of a presupposition,² probably seems absurd to most of us who have been reared and geared to proceed from the opposite assumption. It must, however, be admitted that "any notion of 'the natural disharmony of interests' is, despite appearances, no more empirical than its opposite."³ If it may be

¹Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 2. (my underlines)

²Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), p. 44 footnote.

³Ibid.

agreed that the existence or non-existence of a particular God is beyond empirical proof⁴, then a conception of a common "good of all"⁵ which is predicated upon a conception of God would also be beyond the capacity of the scientific method to verify or disprove.

To even begin to understand the thought of Vinoba Bhave, therefore, it is necessary to realize that it "represents the Indian Idealistic tradition of the Vedanta."⁶ Admitting having studied the works of Shankaracharya, a formulator of this tradition, "more than of anyone else,"⁷ Vinoba agreed with that teacher in holding that "therein dwells in every man the same spirit."⁸ This "spirit," also called the soul or self, "is to be sought in our own hearts"⁹ but is, according to Shankara, the same universal soul or Atman which informs all that is. It is in this context that Vinoba observed how "the

⁴See Arnold Brecht, Political Theory: The Foundations of Twentieth Century Political Thought (Princeton, Princeton University Press, 1970), p. 87 etc.

⁵"... the good of all is contained in the good of each," Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 17.

⁶Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 124.

⁷Vinoba Bhave, Language Problem (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965), p. 8

⁸Vinoba Bhave quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1962), p. 471. (my underline)

⁹Ibid., p.169.

beautiful atman within me is within the insect too."¹⁰

Vinoba's ideal of samya yoga, or reverence for all life, accordingly "makes no distinction between man and man" and even sees "no ultimate difference in the spirit of man and other animals."¹¹ Not only do all people "belong to one human family"¹² by virtue of the One God being in each person, but all are viewed as but one manifestation of "that God (who) is present in all the forms of creation."¹³

People, however, are unique in that the human mind alone has the capacity to reflect upon being. As will be discussed later, it is a crucial prerogative of the mind to will attitudes which may either impede spiritual progress or overcome the illusion of separation which allows for final self-realization (moksha) to occur. It is to this end which Vinoba refers when he said that: "the ultimate human good is not subjective, differing from individual to individual, it is uniform in nature."¹⁴ The idea of opposition of interests is itself wrong, therefore, because the only true interest is common to all persons.

Accordingly, for example, religious conflicts are illusory. He recognized that "the growth of dogmas and rigid institutions around religions"¹⁵ has created much division,

¹⁰Vinoba Bhawe, Talks on the Gita (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 137.

¹¹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 471.

¹²Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 250.

¹³Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 131.

¹⁴Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 150.

¹⁵Vinoba Bhawe, Christ The Love Incarnate (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1964), p. 39.

but nevertheless held that "all religions believe in love, compassion, affection and peace, and in this respect they have a common belief."¹⁶ Thus, "all religions are partial embodiments of Truth"¹⁷ or, to put it differently "Hinduism, Islam and other religions are different formulations of only one basic religion, namely, Truth."¹⁸ From Vinoba's viewpoint, therefore, the ethical content of a religion is its essence while "the highest goal of spiritual life lies in the ultimate experience. . . in which the worshipper . . . is merged and becomes one with the Infinite."¹⁹ Because, Vinoba maintained, the essence of every religion is the same, Truth cannot oppose Truth and hence "there can never be opposition between two religions."²⁰

Similarly, Vinoba held that "the worth of a society is judged by its individuals"²¹ who constitute its essence. Since the essence or soul of each individual is the same, Truth that is Atman cannot oppose Truth, and again all conflict is illusion caused by "a false notion of what constitutes our interest."²² Since, in addition, a society is no more than

¹⁶Ibid. pp. 46-47.

¹⁷Vinoba Bhave, Random Reflections (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1971), p. 15. (Truth = Ultimate Reality; Atman.)

¹⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 35.

¹⁹Swami Yatiswarananda, "A Glimpse Into Hindu Religious Symbolism," in The Cultural Heritage of India (Calcutta: Ramakrishna Mission, 1956), Vol. IV, p. 435.

²⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 55.

²¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231.

²²Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values, p. 18

the individuals who compose it, the "basic oneness of all life removes the possibility of conflict between the good of the individual and that of society."²³ The concept of sarvodaya comes to include the belief that "the good of the individual is contained in the good of all"²⁴ as well as the conviction that the good of all is contained in the good of each individual.²⁵

To those who do not believe in a "common good of all" but hold, rather, that the goal should be "the greatest good for the greatest number" Vinoba observed that "utilitarianism takes its utility for granted."²⁶ It fails to be useful, according to Vinoba, when it comes to the ultimate goal of realizing the Oneness of all life. In fact, as we shall see in the next chapter, Vinoba went even further by asserting that utilitarian instrumentalities—like a tradition of "majority rule"—may even serve to inhibit the growth of this realization.

To others, like Marx, who proceed upon the assumption of a conflict of self or class interests, Vinoba complained that such bases undermine "the very foundation of fellow feeling

²³Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 256.

²⁴Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 35.

²⁵To avoid possible confusion, "sarvodaya" as here used should be taken, as in this paper generally, to mean "the sarvodaya of Vinoba Bhave," since, as Indu Tikekar points out in Integral Revolution, pp. 146-147, not all Sarvodaya thinkers are Vedantans.

²⁶Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 104.

and mutual help."²⁷ Indeed, so monistic was Vinoba's perspective that even the concept of "the struggle for existence" is "unjustified"²⁸ as a denial of spiritual unity. Accordingly, while conflicts among individuals are born of ignorance of their common good, Vinoba believed that capitalism and competition, generally, impede the realization of this truth.

Significantly, Vinoba argued that "Capitalism cannot be ended by love or conflict, but by right thought."²⁹ However, right thought" in this context is quite far from Marx's conception of consciousness because it is not dependent, in any way, upon one's material environment. "Right thought" is dependent upon one's bhavana (mental attitude), which has "the power to transform all things."³⁰ Indeed, in this sense, "it is the eye of the beholder that determines the form of the world,"³¹ not vice versa. Capitalism, in this context, is caused, like all "sources" of conflict, by a wrong attitude or perspective as to what is real in the world.

Vinoba held that the source of all wrong attitudes is taught to one by one's environment. This source is the bhavana that "I am the body" which "builds a wall around me and cuts me off"³² from others. Vinoba observed how "from childhood we are taught to worship this deity, the body" and "we impress on the child's mind the idea that he is the

²⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 9.

²⁸Ibid., p. 179.

²⁹Vinoba Bhawe, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 130.

³⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 108.

³¹Ibid., p. 109.

³²Ibid., p. 12. www.vinoba.in

body."³³ This, argued Vinoba, emphasizes the notion of "difference"³⁴ upon the individual and builds a life "on the foundation of fear"³⁵ which is conducive to selfishness and conflict.

According to Vinoba "obsession with the flesh is the source of all fear"³⁶ and "it is because of fear that tyranny becomes possible."³⁷ When people fall into "the whirlpool of beautifying the body"³⁸ and seek only to gratify their sensual desires and whims, naturally conflicts arise and the most physically strong and mentally clever will exploit others for their own ends. Those others, more often than not, will endure the exploitation because of the fear they hold with regard to asserting themselves.

The way to overcome this fear and, according to Vinoba, to progress to a realization of the Oneness of all life is to understand the truth of the Bhagavad Gita's thirteenth chapter: "Tat tvam asi" which means "'You are Indeed the Self,' you are not the body, you are the Self."³⁹ As interpreted by Vinoba this means that the Self or Atman in every person is "altogether distinct from the body, separate, entirely beautiful, bright, holy, and free of imperfection."⁴⁰ It is, in

³³Ibid., p. 162.

³⁴Ibid., p. 231.

³⁵Ibid., p. 163.

³⁶Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 31.

³⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 167.

³⁸Ibid., p. 166.

³⁹Ibid.

⁴⁰Ibid., p. 163.
www.vinoba.in

short "indestructible, flawless, transcending the body"⁴¹ and, hence, worthy to be exalted.

The revolutionary flavor of this perspective may become more apparent as we see that "no true safety is possible so long as there is attachment to the body and consequent fear."⁴² The possibility of "real freedom" in either a spiritual or political sense, moreover, presupposes a conquering of fear since:

. . . when you give up attachment to the body, you become an emperor, you achieve freedom. All power comes into your hands. No one can exercise authority over you. - The very basis of tyranny breaks down. . . .⁴³

"True safety" and "real freedom," in this context, consist in willfully surrendering to the Self who then "guides us all from within."⁴⁴ In a word, they consist in attaining to the ideal of moksha. Thus, while God has given us freedom to identify ourselves with the body, God has also given the mind the capacity to will a new bhavana by which attachment to the body may be transcended.⁴⁵ To be truly free and safe in either a spiritual or political sense, therefore, requires that we progressively realize that "common good" which is moksha and individually admit that "I am the Self." It is the extent to which this bhavana is mastered, according to Vinoba, that each individual "is then emperor of the world."⁴⁶

⁴¹Ibid., p. 167.

⁴²Ibid., p. 169.

⁴³Ibid., p. 168.

⁴⁴Ibid., p. 8.

⁴⁵Ibid.

⁴⁶Ibid., p. 169.

This, however, ought not to be taken to mean that the body should be mortified in any way. While one must, according to Vinoba, see that "I am not this mortal body . . . I am the spirit that never dies,"⁴⁷ one must also realize that "the body has been given to me for the sake of the Self."⁴⁸ "The body is like one's clothes"⁴⁹ or a "machine"⁵⁰ which should be well used as an "instrument,"⁵¹ in the service of God's will. It needs to be treated well in other words, since it is a prerequisite for doing one's duty.⁵²

In Hindu tradition "everybody has a duty to fulfill."⁵³ In fact,

The very start of the teachings of the Gita is based on the principle that whatever might be the position in which a man is placed at birth, if he performs his duty with love, devotion, and singleness of purpose, he becomes worthy of moksha (self-realization).⁵⁴

This duty, or svadharma, consists of two parts according to Vinoba: the dharma, which changes, and the "natural duties" which never change.⁵⁵

⁴⁷Ibid., p. 13.

⁴⁸Ibid., p. 14.

⁴⁹Ibid., p. 14.

⁵⁰Ibid., p. 165.

⁵¹Ibid., p. 16.

⁵²Generally, for most Hindus, including Vinoba, God's Will = to do one's duty.

⁵³Vinoba Bhave, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957), p. 3.

⁵⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 39.

⁵⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 245.

To interpret dharma as changeable is highly revolutionary in the context of the traditional caste system. That system holds that "One's dharma consists in following one's true vocation"⁵⁶ which is, by nature, that which one is born into. Vinoba, however, held that "the idea of associating birth in poverty or prosperity with previous life is totally absurd."⁵⁷ "True vocation," for him, is thrown open to change as he argued that "as the course of one's life changes through thinking and experience, one's old dharma drops off and a new dharma comes in its place."⁵⁸

There are, however, duties which are natural and unchanging, for example:

The service of the parents to whom I was born, the service of the neighbors amongst whom I find myself, these duties come to me naturally . . . my other obligations are matters of everyday experience. I feel hungry, I feel thirsty. So, to give food to the hungry and drink to the thirsty becomes my duty by nature.⁵⁹

While the doctrine of karma yoga, later to be discussed, will explain much of why such duties are "natural", there is, I believe, an additional rationale: a categorical imperative. Vinoba believed that

The criterion which is employed in the science of ethics for determining whether from the point of view of morals a principle is right or wrong, and whether from a practical point of view it is advantageous or disadvantageous,

⁵⁶Ibid., p. 8.

⁵⁷Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 243.

⁵⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 7.

⁵⁹Ibid., p. 185.

is to extend it to apply to all people and see what the result is.⁶⁰

Since, as has been mentioned, the body "is given to us as a means, an instrument"⁶¹ to be used in God's service, and since the instrument needs to be well cared for to be of full service, to be denied basic bodily needs is an impediment to doing one's svadharma. Vinoba's admonition "to foster and cherish the body because only so can one perform one's svadharma"⁶² linked with an imperative to "do unto others as you would have them do unto you"⁶³ thus, at least, means that insofar as one has more than one needs for physical well being, one's duty is to "give food to the hungry and drink to the thirsty."

Although "physical well-being" admittedly has different needs from individual to individual,⁶⁴ still "the body is to be paid its due hire--no more than that"⁶⁵ or one will tend to fall back into the spirit-denying "I am the body" bhavana. Clearly this would seem to be the basis from which Mira Behn, another disciple of Gandhi, criticized Vinoba's occasional acceptance of land gifts from the very poor: such gifts do not allow the giver's body its "due hire."⁶⁶

⁶⁰Vinoba Bhave, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959), p. 83.

⁶¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 163.

⁶²Ibid., p. 16.

⁶³Vinoba, Christ, the Love Incarnate, p. 22 (see also: The New Testament, Matthew 5-7).

⁶⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 43.

⁶⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 16. (underlines mine)

⁶⁶Mira Behn, noted by Vera Michelas Dean in "India: A New
www.vinoba.in

Vinoba did fall into apparent contradiction, as he observed, during the Bhoodan Movement, that "the first step to bring about Sarvodaya . . . is antyodaya—the uplift of the last one."⁶⁷ Accordingly, he taught that "it is also the duty of the poor kisan to give"⁶⁸ because, from the point of view of the landless, he is somewhat better off."⁶⁹ This, he argued, would "give rise to a moral power that would affect the rich"⁷⁰ —something which he saw actually happen on many occasions.⁷¹ Thus, according to Vinoba,

. . . everybody must make some sacrifice for the sake of those who are the most distressed in society even as all water of the globe flows towards the sea standing at the lowest level.⁷²

Clearly, however, as the sea level rises, the poorer people who once gave more than they could afford would be subsumed in the giving. Thus, while Vinoba might depart from the rationale of Mira Behn until a basic subsistence level is established for all, that rationale might well be used by Vinoba to support his call for all to perform their svadharma. In the meantime even the poor would have an opportunity to discover that each person "experiences joy and fulfillment in

Gandhi Walks the Dusty Roads," Reporter 9: Oct. 1953, p. 21.

⁶⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 181.

⁶⁸Kisan: one who works with his hands, in this case one who already needs all the land he has.

⁶⁹Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 2.

⁷⁰Ibid., p. 4.

⁷¹See Suresh Ram's numerous accounts in Vinoba and His Mission.

⁷²Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 2.

the measure which he gives."⁷³

At any rate, Vinoba held that because human nature is social no person can partake of any good thing alone and find happiness.⁷⁴ Proceeding from his metaphysical premise that "in reality it is impossible to separate the individual and society"⁷⁵ Vinoba saw the prevailing values in a society as having a basis in the consensus of the people in that society. By mobilizing even the poor to adopt a new value orientation the status conferred upon the rich by the old order is undermined. "Moral pressure" is thus exerted with the aim of giving "the opportunity to the rich to give vent to their generous nature."⁷⁶

This is not to say, however, that people are simply "good" by nature. For Vinoba: "none but God is wholly free from blemish . . . none too is an embodiment of absolute evil."⁷⁷ Of course, that God who "dwells in the hearts of all beings"⁷⁸ is, by definition, good. Still, while "the natural movement of one's soul is upwards" it is believed that "the burden of the body drags down the soul."⁷⁹ Human beings, accordingly,

⁷³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 209.

⁷⁴Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 53.

⁷⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231. (It may be noteworthy to observe that at times Vinoba uses an organic analogy: "Just as between the different limbs and the organs of the body there is no conflict, but only harmony and cooperation, so too between individuals in society," Ibid., p. 232.)

⁷⁶Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 21.

⁷⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 2.

⁷⁸Vinoba, Bhoo-dan Yajna, p. 8.

⁷⁹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 176.

have the potential for evil as well as goodness insofar as the mind dwells upon the selfish comforts of the body. Indeed

There are many external forms assumed by the illusion that strews with thorns the path of svadharma. Yet, if we examine them, only one thing is at the bottom of it all, namely, a restricted and shallow identification of oneself with the body.⁸⁰

In Vinoba's framework "change always goes on"⁸¹ because the attractions of the body and the desire of the soul to realize itself are in a constant tension. It is in this context that he observed how "the Gita uses the allegory of war" and maintains that "to speak the truth, the real battle is only within ourselves."⁸² Full self-realization (Moksha), accordingly, becomes an ideal to be approached as one progressively abandons the bhavana of "I am the body." Hence, Vinoba observed how

I would say that ours is to secure control over all our senses, mind and heart. We refuse to be slave of them. Whence our Vedic Rishis⁸³ gave us the mantra 'Yatemahi Swarajya' (we shall strive to attain this Swaraj).⁸⁴ Individual swaraj (self-rule) becomes, in this context, a prerequisite to moksha! Rule of the Self over the body is attained as the mind is able to separate the two ⁸⁵ in one's consciousness. To be able to do this, Vinoba agreed with the orthodox Hindus, one must successfully overcome the "three

⁸⁰Ibid., p. 12.

⁸¹Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 131.

⁸²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 208.

⁸³Rishi = Holy man, Sannyasin.

⁸⁴Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 128.

⁸⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 177.

gunas."⁸⁶ These "qualities of nature" are assumed present in all forms of life⁸⁷ and were, for Vinoba, represented in man primarily by laziness (tamas),⁸⁸ personal ambition (rajas)⁸⁹, and knowledge (sattva).⁹⁰ They may also be conceived of as being represented in one's instincts, emotions, and intellect, respectively.⁹¹

To overcome any instinctual laziness was, for Vinoba, essential for the maintenance of a healthy body which, as has been shown, is a prerequisite for doing one's svadharma. According to him, "experience shows that just as the mind is influenced by bodily sickness, so also good health has a bearing on mind."⁹² The more lazy one is, or the more one's bodily needs are not met, therefore, the more one tends to think "I am the body."

Tamas is, accordingly, overcome by the performance of bodily labor.⁹³ This cure, moreover, has social significance insofar as Vinoba applied his categorical imperative—extending this individual good to all members of the society. Seeing how many people are entrapped by tamas due to their exploitation of the labor of others, Vinoba argued that it is

⁸⁶Ibid.

⁸⁷See Alain Danielou, Hindu Polytheism (New York: Pantheon Books, 1964), pp. 21-62 for an elaboration.

⁸⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 177.

⁸⁹Ibid., p. 186.

⁹⁰Ibid., p. 187.

⁹¹L. A. Varma, "Rituals of Worship," The Cultural Heritage of India, p. 454.

⁹²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 179.

⁹³Ibid., p. 177.

in the spiritual interest of the rich to work with their own hands. He asserted that

All inequality, all ideas of high and low, slavery and violence have originated chiefly from the economic sin of avoiding bodily labor.⁹⁴

Thus, as one identifies oneself with the body, so also one may extend that identification to building up a corporation or a large plantation which one considers "necessary" in order not to work. Such economic walls also are in conflict with Vinoba's desire to establish a "welfare of all" consciousness.⁹⁵

If one has not, in addition, overcome rajas, one will be subject to emotional judgment generally, and personal ego fulfillment in particular. Where the identification with an illusory individual ego is not strong, there will be "unsteadiness" of purpose, according to Vinoba.⁹⁶ Where the ego is strong, one is predicted to either overextend oneself in one's activities, so as to do little well (a violation of dharma) or, in the very least, one will perpetuate one's bhavana of "separateness" which is, of course, a spiritual barrier.

To live "within the limits of svadharma"⁹⁷ is the major step to take in the effort to destroy the rajasic element. One must, accordingly, confine one's actions and service to

⁹⁴Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 28.

⁹⁵As an alternative to "private ownership," therefore, Vinoba advocated either collective ownership by the community, or a spirit of absolute trusteeship in the rich, which come to the same thing in his formulation.

⁹⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 187.

⁹⁷Ibid. www.vinoba.in

one's most immediate surroundings first.⁹⁸ After one's parents and neighbors are well taken care of, svadharma's sphere is allowed to legitimately grow. Such a focus on the "nearest" is considered to be good combat against the ego's belief in its own capacity to "change the world." Humility is fostered.

There is, in addition, the crucial importance of the results of one's actions for both the tamas and rajas-dominated individuals. Vinoba observed how

The attitude that if I perform any act, I must also enjoy its fruit, illustrates the dominance of the Rajasic-element. On the other hand, the attitude that if I have to give up the fruit, I shall refrain from all action itself, betrays a Tamas-dominated nature.⁹⁹

The basis for such attachment to the fruits of one's actions is egoism—the sense of one's separateness from others. Thus, egoism must be conquered first before one can seek freedom from attachment.

"Egoism is conquered by constancy in sattva."¹⁰⁰ The intellect, or reason, the faculty which allows us to accumulate knowledge, unlike rajas and tamas "should be wounded, but not killed"¹⁰¹ since it is conceived as the way by which we may discover how similar we are to other beings and how little, as individuals, we can do in this world. Also involved in this "constancy in sattva" is the removing of our identification with our mind which was, for Vinoba, to transcend

⁹⁸This is called the principle of Swadeshi in the political realm.

⁹⁹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 13.

¹⁰⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 190.

¹⁰¹Ibid., p. 187.

our attachment to it.¹⁰²

One way to achieve victory over sattva, and hence, over egoism, is to so live that "sattva becomes so much our nature that we would cease to be proud of it."¹⁰³ In saying this Vinoba nevertheless agreed that the ways to God-realization of jnana and raja yoga, through knowledge and psychological exercises respectively,¹⁰⁴ are paths suited for only a few temperaments. For the masses of humanity, however, he agreed with most Hindus, sattva may be overcome only as "attachment is conquered by giving up the desire for results, and dedicating all to the Lord."¹⁰⁵ Thus, Vinoba admitted, "our reliance is solely on Him to Whom we have dedicated our life. This is the path of devotion or Bhakti."¹⁰⁶

While Vinoba held that individual swaraj can be achieved by "straight and simple bhakti"¹⁰⁷, the key to understanding the political relevance of this is to realize that the object of the loving devotion is not some historical incarnation or other abstract principle or entity, but mankind today. Vinoba's bhavana of bhakti teaches that "one should look upon all men and women as so many images of God."¹⁰⁸ Since, for Vinoba,

¹⁰²Ibid., p. 188 (One's mind, in other words, must be transcended.)

¹⁰³Ibid., p. 189.

¹⁰⁴See Huston Smith, The Religions of Man (New York: Harper & Row, 1965), pp. 36-39 and 51-52 especially, respectively.

¹⁰⁵Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 190.

¹⁰⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 107.

¹⁰⁷Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 102.

¹⁰⁸Vinoba, www.vinoba.in, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 19.

"Brahmin¹⁰⁹ meant any lofty exalted idea"¹¹⁰ pertaining to life, "Society" became, for him, worthy of the devotion of individuals.¹¹¹

Directing one's loving devotion, or bhakti, to Society, is, of course, consistent with Vinoba's Advaita Vedanta framework. Earlier it was noted how, according to this framework, there is no real conflict between individuals and society. Later it was discovered that the sense of attachment to the fruits of one's actions, and hence the gunas, could only be overcome "dedicating all to the Lord." Hence Vinoba combined the orthodox maxim that "renunciation of fruit is yoga, the art of living"¹¹² with his own objective of renunciation of private ownership to God, or Society, ¹¹³ as a means of land redistribution.

According to Vinoba:

A psychological change like this cannot be brought about by war and violent revolution. It can only be brought about by the methods of Buddha, Christ, Ramanuja and other great teachers. Ultimately, it is to be the dedication of one's all for the well being of all.¹¹⁴ The means of ahimsa, or nonviolence,¹¹⁵ is in this context,

¹⁰⁹Brahmin is another name for the One, Undifferentiated, God or Atman.

¹¹⁰Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 32.

¹¹¹Ibid., p. 18.

¹¹²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 19.

¹¹³Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society, p. 62.

¹¹⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 19.

¹¹⁵Vinoba, Language Problem, p. 31.

the only means compatible with bhakti yoga because "we reap what we sow, as is the desire so is the fruit."¹¹⁶ This Law of Karma, which is an important presupposition for Vinoba, recognizes that "it is possible to be non-violent in externals, and yet in fact be filled with violence"¹¹⁷ which, as a "quality of the mind"¹¹⁸ will impede the realization of the spiritual Oneness of all life. Thus, Vinoba responded to the question of "why should we love?" by simply saying that "from this the harmony of oneness is generated. This is Vedanta."¹¹⁹

Indeed, the means of love (agape: self-giving) and individual swaraj may be conceived of as inseparable components of the need which, if fostered by the mind's bhavana shall grow into the tree of moksha. Thus, "the individual 'ego' can be dedicated to God only after it has been merged in the collective 'ego'"¹²⁰ and this latter can be accomplished only through progressive identification with and loving devotion to all that lives. Even for the materially oppressed, therefore, "to resort to cruelty for freeing oneself from the blame of cowardly behavior is like flying from the frying pan into the fire."¹²¹

For the non-Vedantan, Vinoba argued that nonviolence, or love, is not only intrinsically good but is also practical from an instrumental perspective. Speaking broadly, for

¹¹⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 27.

¹¹⁷Ibid., p. 36.

¹¹⁸Ibid.

¹¹⁹Vinoba, Christ, the Love Incarnate, p. 34.

¹²⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 87

¹²¹Vinoba, www.vinoba.in Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 48.

example, Vinoba observed that

. . . the Communists consider everyone among the rich as an enemy of the poor. This attitude (bhavana) makes the good as well as the bad¹²² among the rich join together with the result that the wicked among them gain more strength.¹²³

Class warfare, moreover, is "a process of revolution based on violence, is verily a process of reaction which can only result in counter-revolution"¹²⁴ for at least two reasons. First, it alienates potential allies within the opponent's class whose physical destruction is a loss of a well-educated and entrepreneurial resource who, as trustees, could be of great service to society.¹²⁵

Secondly, if we want a concern for human life to be increased, or, ideally, for even our opponent to improve in this regard, "we cannot do so by the use of physical force, which only heightens the body sense."¹²⁶ By threatening another's life, we destroy any consciousness that person has

¹²²This should not be taken to mean that anyone can be totally "bad" or "wicked," for there is no devil theory in Sarvodaya. Rather, the terms are here used to denote the effects of one's actions. See Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 131, "we only look to the means he employs."

¹²³Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 16.

¹²⁴Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 28.

¹²⁵Generally, "trusteeship" is the alternative which both Gandhi and Vinoba advocated. Ultimately, for both, the "trustees" by their "trusteeship" makes use of all their wealth for the good of society.

¹²⁶Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 163.

of existing oneness, and remove the small possibility of rational communication since the atmosphere is charged with fear.

Vinoba maintained that "what the world appears to us to be depends on the vision we have of it."¹²⁷ Hence, the bhavana (mental attitude) that another individual or class of people are "enemies" tends to make them appear to be enemies because that is what we draw out of them. Treated like enemies they usually act like enemies, thus reaffirming the bhavana.

What Vinoba advocated, in his bhavana of bhakti, was to refuse to act like an enemy even if an opponent considers one as such. This bhavana can make "the undeserving deserving and the evil good"¹²⁸ since, through non-retaliation, the conception of one as a threatening "enemy" is difficult to sustain. Moreover, it encourages communication and the seeking of Truth (which no one is, again, completely without) by refraining from a self-righteous or absolute judgment. Hence, Vinoba said:

Who is to decide that anyone (as such) is bad? Even if a really bad person appears before you, think that it is the Lord Himself. Even a villain will become a saint.¹²⁹

Vinoba's idealism, however, ought not to be labeled romantic primarily because he did not overlook the necessity of suffering. He clearly held that "attachment to the body is not love. On the contrary, unless attachment to the body is

¹²⁷Ibid., p. 69.

¹²⁸Ibid., p. 109.

¹²⁹Ibid. www.vinoba.in

put away, true love does not emerge."¹³⁰ True love, is, in fact, involved in loving one's enemy¹³¹ with a Christ-like readiness to lay down one's life rather than do harm to another. Observed Vinoba:

The body perishes every moment, understanding this, let us use it for the sake of svadharma. When there is need, let us not hesitate even to give it up for the sake of svadharma.¹³²

This may seem to contradict the earlier observation that, for Vinoba, the body was a prerequisite for attaining to God or Self-realization. However, in the context of his means-ends analysis, it should be clear that for him the means of Love (nonviolence or nonretaliation), is the seed which grows into the tree of Truth that is God realized in moksha. Thus, in swaraj the body is to be made to work and receive its noble service¹³³ but

Whenever there is a chance of the Supreme principle being defiled . . . I shall ever be ready to offer up the body in sacrifice in order to keep the flame of the Self brightly burning.¹³⁴

While, therefore, to attain perfect individual swaraj or self-realization requires one to be perfectly loving, Vinoba nevertheless held that "there is nothing impossible for the soul"¹³⁵ and that "thought-force has no limitations."¹³⁶ The

¹³⁰Ibid., p. 15.

¹³¹Vinoba, Christ the Love Incarnate, p. 34.

¹³²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 17.

¹³³Ibid., p. 163.

¹³⁴Ibid., p. 167.

¹³⁵Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 37.

¹³⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 9.

objective that "my ego should completely get destroyed"¹³⁷ is attainable if, at the point of death, one is so unattached to one's body as to dedicate all to the Lord, the Atman. To be so loving has, as an ideal, that of Jesus who is quoted by Vinoba as saying, "Thy will be done, Lord, forgive them for they know not what they do."¹³⁸

Like a Christian who believes "faith" and "works" to be inseparable, so also Vinoba believed that "Bhakti yoga must be coupled with Karma yoga."¹³⁹ Bhakti, or loving devotion, is "the disposition to serve" while karma, or action, is the "actual service."¹⁴⁰ Accordingly, "the outer form of love is service"¹⁴¹ which is activity that is never renounced. Indeed, Vinoba held that "to renounce action is impossible for renunciation itself is an act."¹⁴² What is abandoned, ideally, is the sense of an ego either initiating action¹⁴³ or enjoying the fruits thereof.

Vinoba returns to the body/self dichotomy which is so central to his thought when he observed how

Some say: 'a human is an animal who can make tools.' I say: 'a human is an animal who can use the body as a tool for self-realization.'¹⁴⁴

It becomes such a tool not only as the bhavana of bhakti is

¹³⁷Ibid., p. 14.

¹³⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 174. (see Luke 23:34)

¹³⁹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 123.

¹⁴⁰Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 78.

¹⁴¹Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 204.

¹⁴²Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 27.

¹⁴³Ibid., p. 29.

¹⁴⁴Ibid., p. 31

developed within the individual's mind but also insofar as the bhakti is manifested in active service to others. Thus, we are told that "a devotee of God relishes karma yoga, the philosophy of action with non-attachment" because that action is seen as "a form of worship."¹⁴⁵

Such action which has "an opportunity to serve the people," moreover, helps one to learn "to see 'God in every living being.'"¹⁴⁶ Thus, in this context of the necessity for karma yoga, we are better able to see why there are "unchanging duties" also included in one's svadharma. To fail to serve others, beginning with those nearest to one, would be an invitation to the rajasic element to become more dominant. To be willing to do others harm and, supposedly, serve them at the same time would not only violate the means-end relationship but also, if taken to an extreme (as the categorical imperative demands), would destroy the very "other" who is a prerequisite for God-realization.

The individual seeker after swaraj, therefore, is dependent upon the existence of others to be of service to. All persons within a society, then, are viewed as individuals who are "interdependent"¹⁴⁷ upon the same God within each, so to speak. It is in this context that Vinoba observed that "we are, from the beginning, debtors" and how "discharge of the debt is yajna or service, not altruism."¹⁴⁸ Indeed "we have to beware of altruism"¹⁴⁹ not only because it fosters identi-

¹⁴⁵Ibid., p. 50.

¹⁴⁶Ibid., p.17.

¹⁴⁷Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 202.

¹⁴⁸Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 222 (underline mine)

¹⁴⁹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 12.

fication with one's ego but also because it tends to deny that "as we are born, our svadharma is also born with us."¹⁵⁰ The karma yogin, therefore, in addition to performing service for its own sake as a means of "spiritual development"¹⁵¹ also acts out of a sense of duty to the society to which a great debt is owed.

The general formulation of "the Lord to serve, I the servant, and creation the means"¹⁵² becomes, for Vinoba, less personal as the ego is subordinated to "the Lord." Ideally, the individual karma yogin so transcends individual selfishness as to adhere merely to the maxim of "service to an individual and devotion to the whole society."¹⁵³ Individual swaraj is thus attained to as one sees that "in truth, svārtha should be paramārtha, one's own good should be the supreme good"¹⁵⁴ and one identifies "with the community . . . around one."¹⁵⁵

At this point some of the complexity of the relationship between the swaraj (self rule) of individuals and collective swaraj may be appreciated. While true collective swaraj, as alluded to in my introduction, is literally the Sarvodaya ideal of Ramrajya (or the Kingdom of God)¹⁵⁶ it would be unfair to conceive of its approximation as merely the sum of swaraj individuals have attained to. Just as the individual in

¹⁵⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 12

¹⁵¹Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 38.

¹⁵²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 201.

¹⁵³Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 18.

¹⁵⁴Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 231.

¹⁵⁵Ibid., p. 31.

¹⁵⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 70.

society is dependent upon others for the fruitful practice of karma yoga in a spirit of bhakti, so also are those others dependent upon the renunciate's actions for such service as he or she may offer.

As discussed earlier, the bhavana of "I am the body" was recognized, by Vinoba, to be more likely as the body's needs are not met. The actions of the karma yogin, for Vinoba, become truly of service only insofar as they are conducive to the Self of others being realized by them. Accordingly the activity of Vinoba's seeker after Truth is dedicated to providing the material necessities of life to others beginning with those who are in most need. A dialectic of sorts is thus established with both the served and the serving benefiting spiritually.

At times, moreover, Vinoba's plea for individuals to take the responsibility of service upon themselves seemed to take on an air of emergency. For example, he observed that

Unless the existing social order, which is based upon inequality, strife and conflict, is replaced by one founded on equality and mutual cooperation, there can be no salvation for mankind.¹⁵⁷

Quite probably Vinoba's urgency was a reflection of his concern about the potential effects of a nuclear war in today's world.¹⁵⁸ Since the "salvation of mankind", or the

¹⁵⁷Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 19.

¹⁵⁸Vinoba clearly believed that the "path of violence" has reached a dead-end from which mankind must change its course or be destroyed in the collision. See: Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 144-148, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 64, need for a "nonviolent army" Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 24, etc.

www.vinoba.in

collective attainment of Ramrajya, has as a prerequisite the "survival of mankind" it would be no small wonder if Vinoba were disturbed about mushrooms on the horizon.

Be this as it may, Vinoba admitted that he grew from his youthful days to gain a greater concern for collective swaraj.¹⁵⁹ This prompted him, like Gandhi, to conduct expanded experiments of collective action as represented in the Bhoodan and Gramdan movements. Observing how "wherever you turn, you see nothing but walls,"¹⁶⁰ he sought to break down these walls by hammering at their common root: man's bhavana that "I am the body."

By organizing individuals and promulgating the ideal of karma yoga on a mass scale Vinoba hoped to create what he called swatantra loka shakti,¹⁶¹ or "the self-reliant power of the people."¹⁶² This "power of the people" when manifested in different levels of society gave rise to another usage of "swaraj." Thus, as Vinoba used the term, "National swaraj" was attained when independence was won from the British but "gram swaraj" or Village self-rule has not yet been attained.¹⁶³ Progressively, as the individual participates in the movements for national independence, then for regional autonomy and then for village self-reliance, Vinoba believed

¹⁵⁹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 316.

¹⁶⁰Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 13.

¹⁶¹Sometimes "jana" is substituted for "loka" and translated the same way. So, for simplicity's sake, I'll use "loka" here and, consistently, throughout the rest of this book.

¹⁶²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

¹⁶³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 41.

he or she will be brought to understand the ultimate spiritual importance of individual swaraj, and, simultaneously, Ramrajya will be approached.¹⁶⁴

The means to be employed in this enterprise, as might be imagined, are of crucial importance to Vinoba. Karma yoga which is, by definition, the "way to God through right action"¹⁶⁵ is only effective if the "right action" is "right"—that is, as the bhavana of bhakti is manifested in it. Thus, the "power of the people" was, for Vinoba, a power which is "opposed to violence"¹⁶⁶ or even asserting "pressure by the threat of violence."¹⁶⁷ It is based upon "the strength of good public opinion"¹⁶⁸ which, when exerted, always respects the life and integrity of the opponent.¹⁶⁹

When it comes, however, to comparing the swatantra loka shakti with the power of the State which has as its base "the coercive power of law"¹⁷⁰ Vinoba asserted that "though there is no direct opposition," still "the two are qualitatively different."¹⁷¹ For him

¹⁶⁴Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

¹⁶⁵Huston Smith, The Religions of Man, p. 45.

¹⁶⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

¹⁶⁷Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 19.

¹⁶⁸Ibid.

¹⁶⁹Significantly, to the student of Gandhi, Vinoba seemed much less willing to use any kind of coercion (in the sense of making another do that which is against his or her will) than Gandhi. Vinoba tended to equate violence with coercion. See Tikekar, Integral Revolution, pp. 12-13, 221 plus.

¹⁷⁰Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 104.

¹⁷¹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 97.

This insistence on rules (and law) arises from the fact that people are ignorant of the power of the soul. I do not know if there is anything more degrading than this ignorance of one's intrinsic power, the power of the soul.¹⁷²

To understand more fully why dependence upon law is undesirable, according to Vinoba, one must see the issue in the light of his general dislike for authority in any external coercive sense. This dislike, as analyzed in the next chapter, also provides a background to Vinoba's opposition to representative democracy.

¹⁷²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 36.

CHAPTER TWO

ON DEMOCRACY

While the Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement was not written by Vinoba Bhave, the imprint of his thought may be perceived throughout. Nowhere, however, is it more pronounced than in the statement that:

The Sarvodaya movement believes in the supreme importance of the individual. The ultimate goal of all evolution is the full flowering of his . . . creative autonomy. It is only self-knowledge that makes the uniqueness and autonomy not a threat to the world but its most cherished asset.¹

The individual is "supremely important" because the spiritual search for truth, for Parama Samya which is the "ultimate reality" of God,² could, for Vinoba, only be conducted by individuals. As was brought out in the previous chapter, "collective swaraj," while capable of being approached in an organized fashion, is based upon the actions of individuals practicing karma yoga in a bhavana of bhakti. The "self-knowledge" thus attained to involves the "full flowering" of

¹The Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement (Nagpur: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973), p. 22.

²Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 125.

one's "creative autonomy" into a realization of the Vedantic unity of all life. For the mass of individuals in a society to realize the illusoriness of their "separate" interests requires, within Vinoba's framework, that separate individuals come to progressively perceive the "good of all" through undertaking a life of loving service.

The vision of the common "good of all" is, moreover, impeded insofar as one is taught, or acquires, the bad bhavana of "I am the body." This attitude, however, is not confined to merely one's physical body but was extended, in Vinoba's thought, to include any attachment whatsoever. It is thus that Vinoba explained how "one person puts up an enclosure called 'attachment to family' and lives in it" while "another builds and lives in an enclosure called 'attachment to nation.'"³ Attachment to one's particular family, in this context, erects a spiritual barrier to realizing the human family while attachment to nation similarly impedes the essential idea that we are all citizens of the world. Indeed, for Vinoba, every object—including "government"—had two forms: an outer body (which breeds attachment) and an inner soul (worthy of devotion).⁴

Though he never went so far as to expressly draw a distinction between "State" and "government," I believe a conception of the "State" as the "outer body" of "government" is implicit in Vinoba's writings. This would explain why he frequently used the terms interchangeably⁵ while, at other times, he

³Vinoba Bhawe, Talks on the Gita (Varansi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), p. 13.

⁴Ibid., p. 161.

⁵See, for example, Vinoba Bhawe, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959), p. 80 etc.

appeared to more sharply separate the two concepts. For example, on the one hand "government" is somewhat countenanced, particularly if it is based upon widespread citizen participation,⁶ but on the other hand the "State" is consistently denounced as destructive of "individual initiative."⁷

In this context Vinoba's observation that "Sarvodaya" stands for "freedom from government, it means decentralization of power"⁸ becomes significant. Vinoba distinguished the "freedom from government" objective from a "no government" ideal⁹ insofar as in the former "government" functions are modeled "upon the divine government—unseen, unfelt, and decentralized."¹⁰ Thus, insofar as "government" is decentralized it represents the divine ideal—the ideal of Ram Rajya,¹¹ the Kingdom of God, becoming into concrete existence.

It now appears that what has been called the "anarchism" of

⁶Numerous examples of this point will be cited later, in connection with Vinoba's conception of democracy.

⁷Vinoba Bhave, Gramdan for Gramswaraj (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 49.

⁸Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 3.

⁹Vinoba Bhave distinguished the two, as quoted by Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 48.

¹⁰Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 17.

¹¹Vinoba Bhave, "Ramrajya . . . is what I call Sarvodaya," quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Kashi: Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 70. 

Vinoba Bhawe¹² might be better described as "anti-statism,"¹³ or a dislike of all government to the extent to which it is centralized. That the "State," or the "body aspect" of "government" which is reflected in the principle of centralization, is present in all existing governments was, in addition, recognized by Vinoba. Referring to those in the Sarvodaya Movement, Vinoba noted that

We do not believe in the very institution of Centralized Government . . . this is a fundamental point of principle. And on this point, my opposition is there with all governments in the world, not excluding my own.¹⁴

The primary ground upon which Vinoba's extreme opposition to the State was based is, essentially, spiritual. As the bhavana of "I am the body" impedes the achieving of the "I am the Self" attitude, so also does the bhavana of "statism" prevent the individual from realizing that Swaraj or self-government "means ruling your own self."¹⁵ This is not to say that the State may not provide its citizens with valuable material benefits since he admits that "political power can be an instrument of service."¹⁶ It is, however, to say that "the good work which is done by government services is very

¹²See Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Curell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971), pp. 32-44.

¹³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 418, 173 etc.

¹⁴Vinoba, quoted by Bondurant and Fisher, Indian Approaches, p. 69.

¹⁵Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 13.

¹⁶Vinoba Bhawe, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 87.
www.vinoba.in

far from good in its effect upon the minds of the people."¹⁷

There was, we may recall, a spiritual requirement for every karma yogin, as a karma yogin, to adopt the active responsibility to serve society. In this context, one danger which State services pose is that, perhaps unwittingly, an attitude of "others will do the work of service" will be fostered instead of developing the habit of asking "Of what use could I be?"¹⁸ According to Vinoba the former attitude is the one which, on the whole, is in fact fostered, thus erecting a spiritual barrier against realizing the "oneness" of all life. While this was, of course, a subjective judgment upon his part, it would seem that it is certainly not an irrational conclusion.

Another danger, consistent with Vinoba's framework, is that the State might actually provide all of the services necessary for its citizens. In the last chapter it was shown how, even prior to one's becoming a karma yogin, performance of bodily labor was seen as necessary for overcoming the tamasic element in one's nature. Of course, it is conceivable that the State could provide ample opportunity for physical work if that were considered a "need" of the citizen. Vinoba would seem to have considered such a policy as unlikely especially since an attitude of general laziness would have been prompted in other areas.

If, however, a program of mandatory labor were to be enforced by the State, either physically or through subtle indoctrination, Vinoba would still have opposed it. This

¹⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 12.

¹⁸Vinoba Bhawe, Random Reflections (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1971), p. 108.

opposition would be best understood by a thorough examination of Vinoba's statement that

It is one mark of swaraj not to allow any outside power in the world to exercise control over oneself. And the second mark of swaraj is not to exercise power over any other . . . no submission and no exploitation.¹⁹

To allow oneself to be ruled by external forces meant, for Vinoba, that one is not "ruling oneself" which is the essence of individual swaraj.²⁰ To have attained to this swaraj is, moreover, to have voluntarily surrendered oneself to the rule of "niti", the moral law,²¹ which consists of one's performing one's svadharma. Because, by presumption, the individual as a karma yogin must seek self-realization on his or her own, for the State (or even tradition) to enforce a particular dharma upon one must be resisted. "Where there is a raj, a coercive government, niti is destroyed"²² because limitations are thereby placed upon the internal rule of the "moral law."

On the other hand, to exercise power over others, in the sense of exploiting them for one's own ends, destroys individual swaraj as the ego is given new life by such activity. It would, according to Vinoba's framework, not only increase the rajasic element in one's nature but would, in addition, violate the categorical imperative by not doing "unto others as you would have them do unto you." In both cases the realization of the spiritual end would be impeded by the Law of Karma which decrees that what is sown shall be reaped. Thus for

¹⁹Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 13-14.

²⁰Ibid., p. 13.

²¹Ibid., p. 15.

²²Ibid. www.vinoba.in

Vinoba, "One is a real lover of freedom, who feels that one also must not rule over others."²³

It is only, therefore, to the extent to which individual swaraj is both allowed and fought for (using non-violent means, of course) that the ideal of Ramrajya is approached. This means, within Vinoba's religious-conceptual framework, that "The standard of life should be distinguished from the standard of living" and that "it is the former that is fundamental, not the latter."²⁴ While the "Welfare State," for example, may serve to increase the standard of living²⁵, it fails, according to Vinoba, to increase the "standard of life" which is not so dependent upon material satisfactions. The Welfare State, accordingly, like any other State, "becomes an ill-fated State"²⁶ by impeding the spiritual development of people.

To the extent, therefore, that power comes to be concentrated in the hands of the State, even a Welfare State²⁷ acting in the service of its citizens, the rule of niti is reduced and spiritual barriers are placed along the path of individual swaraj. Since all centralization of power in government was thus, quite logically,²⁸ considered to be to

²³Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 54.

²⁴K. G. Mashruwala, Towards Sarvodaya Order (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1971), pp. 99-100.

²⁵Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 41.

²⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 290.

²⁷Ibid.

²⁸Logically: within the framework of Vinoba's religious thought.

vis-a-vis
Gandhi

the spiritual detriment of individuals, how much greater is the detriment, according to Vinoba, when the State can make the masses believe it "represents" them!²⁹ Thus, for Vinoba, the conclusion is implicit that representative democracy stifles the development of each person as a spiritual being.³⁰ Indeed, he argued:

The truth is that no real freedom exists today, and we shall not get it so long as we carry on with our 'representative democracy' and do not take the management of our village affairs into our own hands.³¹

While the "State," in Vinoba's thought, may be identified with "government" (to the extent to which power is centralized), "representative democracy" correspondingly connotes a condemnable form of "democracy." In that form, Vinoba complained about how the mass of citizens take it "as a matter of course that anything to be done is the responsibility of the elected representatives."³² They become "sheep"³³ who, allowing the State to perform much of their svadharma for them, become spiritually impoverished even as they may be materially benefited.³⁴ He would, in this context, agree that

²⁹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 71.

³⁰This is my deduction, first mentioned in the introduction to this paper.

³¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, pp. 64-65.

³²Vinoba Bhawe, Election and Democracy (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 23.

³³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 12.

³⁴Vinoba, giving Britain and the U.S. as examples, Election and Democracy, p. 18.

The fundamental problem is the powerlessness and fatalism of the people . . . their lack of faith in themselves and the future they are capable of building.³⁵

The swatantra loka shakti, or "self-reliant power of the people,"³⁶ can only be generated, according to Vinoba, as a new bhavana is adopted which maintains that in a participatory democracy "the people are everything and the government nothing."³⁷ The attitude that "the State has power over me" must be abandoned as power passes "into the hands of the people"³⁸ in more than a rhetorical sense. Vinoba claimed that representative democracy is "only a formal democracy"³⁹ because people really only exercise power at election time, thus leaving the representative-elite free to rule, in interim periods, as they please.⁴⁰ For the masses to experience a liberation from their sheepish attitudes, Vinoba concluded, they must actively participate, as karma yogins, in both the formulation and execution of policies.⁴¹

It is in this context that Vinoba observed how the "essence of democracy lies in the control of people over the government."⁴² To the extent that people as individuals "control"

³⁵The Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement , p. 63.

³⁶Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 86.

³⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 20.

³⁸Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 102.

³⁹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 20.

⁴⁰Vinoba Bhawe, quoted by Adi H. Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (London: Asia Publishing House, 1967), p. 19.

⁴¹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 312.

⁴²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 9.

the government, that "government" becomes decentralized and the power of the State is reduced. This process of decentralization, which was viewed as approaching the ideal of Ram rajya, involves a progressive emphasis upon small scale units, like villages,⁴³ as the main units of government. Larger units, like regional federations,⁴⁴ would, in Vinoba's scheme, be countenanced as helpful for purposes of coordination of non-violent defense and utilization of resources, but would also be without recognized power to enforce their decisions.⁴⁵ Thus the mass of people would be given freer reign to participate in all matters which affect their lives and spiritual growth would be enhanced in the process.

It should be emphasized that Vinoba's allegiance to the primacy of small village units confines his notion of a justifiable polity to an extremely decentralized level. The concept of "nation," for example, is rendered as unnecessary as the perceived necessity for delegating authority in a large, centralized unit. Vinoba was, in fact, repudiating the developmental course of many areas which define "progress" mainly in material terms. In his village society ideal the spiritual "progress" of people to moksha (true freedom)

⁴³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 30.

⁴⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 106.

⁴⁵Such bodies, according to Vinoba, would rule by moral pre-eminence, by formulating policies which would so represent the consensus already arrived at as not to require any coercion to enforce them. Conflicts, should they arise before such an ideal is attained to, would be handled by "Satyagraha": non-violent resistance in the Gandhian tradition. (See Vinoba, Swaraaj Sastra, Vinoba Bhave.)

was of the foremost importance and, decentralized as the structure may be, delegation of authority through such means as elections was considered quite unnecessary.

Vinoba, furthermore, opposed the "election demon"⁴⁶ because the formal right to vote was, in his view, "like the right of the sheep to elect a shepherd."⁴⁷ Instead of encouraging the masses to individual performance of svadharma, it promotes a bhavana of having done one's duty at the ballot box. As it discourages continued participation in the political process it increases the centralization of power in the hands of a few. Indeed it is not difficult, at this point, to perceive how Vinoba concluded that:

The whole arrangement, in fact, is sheer bogus. . . .

It does even more harm than our former kings could do because our governments can now claim to 'represent public opinion.'⁴⁸

In addition to objecting to the veil of legitimacy constructed by virtue of elections Vinoba had a fundamental dislike for the principle of majority rule. He recognized that majority rule reflects the doctrine of "the greatest good for the greatest number"⁴⁹—a dictum which inherently denies the Sarvodaya view of "the common good of all." It constituted, in practice, "a new type of caste-difference"⁵⁰ which, while perhaps more fluid than the static caste tradition, nevertheless presents barriers which need to be overcome.

⁴⁶Vinoba, Democratic Values, p.84.

⁴⁷Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 28.

⁴⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 71.

⁴⁹Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 98.

⁵⁰Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 21.

Indeed, it promotes a bhavana in which individual conflicts of interest are treated as real and fundamental—quite contrary to the Sarvodaya teaching.

The majority rule principle also violates the means-ends relationship of Vinoba which condemned the coercing another to act contrary to his or her will.⁵¹ Vinoba asked:

Is not the rule of majority only brute force? How can you differentiate between the rule of the regiment, rule of money and rule of the majority?⁵²

His answer was, implicitly, that "brute force is brute force" whatever its rationale may be and, as such, represents "raj" (coercive state power). Since "raj," as has already been explained, is an impediment to the development of "niti" (moral rule), and hence of the "power of the people," majority rule was consistently denounced within the context of Vinoba's framework.

Furthermore, Vinoba asserted, "right and wrong cannot be decided by majority vote."⁵³ Only individuals, in his conception, should decide right and wrong—although there is a place for opinion leaders who, by virtue of the respect they hold within a community, exercise a greater influence in

⁵¹Naturally, there are all sorts of problems in describing violence in this way. For example, one must know both what another's will is and what he or she would "otherwise do" before one can judge whether violent coercion is involved. Empirically, this is, at least at present, impossible.

⁵²Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 21. (brute force = backed by real or threatened physical sanction)

⁵³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. v. (A sentiment held by Dada Dharmadhikari and other Sarvodaya leaders too.)

decision-making.⁵⁴ Only when utilizing the principle of consensus, argued Vinoba, may this "greater influence" of some be reconciled with the duty of all to participate. Responsibility for deciding "right and wrong" is thus never really delegated in his consensus alternative.⁵⁵

Whether or not consensus democracy is a desirable or practical alternative to rule by majority is too complex a matter to do justice to here.⁵⁶ What is important to note is that consensus does not require unanimous agreement. In it a decision is deferred until there is no active opposition to it being implemented.⁵⁷ Any majority, in other words, must

⁵⁴Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 21. (Also, these "opinion leaders" will be dealt with in greater depth later, in a discussion of "capable leaders.")

⁵⁵Of course, a realistic application of this principle presupposes, Vinoba realized, a decentralization of structure into small enough units that differing views might be openly expressed and compromises arrived at.

⁵⁶I encourage the reader to explore these questions, in the context of Indian society, by analyzing the arguments in support of Vinoba made by Sugata Dasgupta in A Great Society of Small Communities (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1968), pp. 50-51. Opposing arguments may be found, for example, in Doctor's Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (already cited), pp. 153-164. Concerning consensus decision-making in the Sarvodaya Movement itself one may turn to the Gentle Anarchists by Ostergaard and Currell, pp. 204-209.

⁵⁷Vishwanath Tandon, The Social and Political Philosophy of Sarvodaya After Gandhi (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965), p. 130.

take into account the minority perspective if any decision is to be arrived at. From a practical standpoint all would be more likely to seek out the "common good of all" since it would be in their perceived "self-interest" to do so. A spirit of cooperation, in consonance with the Sarvodaya ideal would, moreover, be much more emphasized than in any alternative scheme.⁵⁸

As it is, from Vinoba's empirical perspective,

Election and other works decided upon by the majority of opinion, in the name of democracy, have spread the poison of rivalry between parties and organizations in villages.⁵⁹

According to his experience "caste-differences have been fostered by elections in the country"⁶⁰ and other gulfs have been created because of parties seeking political power. He concluded that "It is entirely fictitious to believe that party-politics leads to the welfare of the people"⁶¹ because, among other reasons, parties indulge in "bargain driving" by their nature, while "The only kind of 'service' worthy of the name is disinterested service."⁶²

It should be made clear that it is not differences in views as such that Vinoba lamented, but the establishment of parties seeking power on the bases of these.⁶³ Disservice is

⁵⁸Vinoba, quoted by Tandon, Sarvodaya After Gandhi, pp. 129-130.

⁵⁹Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 278.

⁶⁰Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 21.

⁶¹Ibid., p. 23.

⁶²Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 46.

⁶³Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study, p.

done as rivalries are promoted thus enhancing the bhavana of "I am the body." In the Sarvodaya view "We will have to rise up above the petty considerations of caste, creed, language or province"⁶⁴ but political parties emphasize such distinctions for their own political advantage. This has harmful effects upon interpersonal relations too, since

If any spirit of bargaining, any tendency to invoke legal sanctions, enters into the mutual relationships of two citizens, it destroys the mutual trust and sense of fellowship between them.⁶⁵

"Bargaining" is further condemned even though Vinoba admitted that differences in view are "necessary and inevitable."⁶⁶ Each individual's duty or dharma, is to do what he or she believes to be right according to the perception of truth at any given point in time. Bargaining, in this context, is a violation of dharma, while a free exchange of relative perceptions of truth contributes to the individual's growth into a new dharma or higher consciousness of truth.

From Vinoba's empirical standpoint, therefore, parties stand condemned on the ground that loyalty to a party often overrides loyalty to the pursuit of Truth that is God.⁶⁷ Genuine criticism is stifled as the people become sheep to a shepherd's party⁶⁸ and honest criticism from opposition parties

⁶⁴Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 45.

⁶⁵Dada Dharmadhikari, Introduction to Democratic Values, p. vii.

⁶⁶Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 27.

⁶⁷Ibid.

⁶⁸Ibid., p. 28. www.vinoba.in

is frequently dismissed as partisan.⁶⁹ In this opinion framework, accordingly, Vinoba concluded that "to participate in the party system and in elections is to increase the stranglehold of party politics."⁷⁰

As might be imagined, however, Vinoba opposed political parties also, as political parties. The situation is similar to that of the principle of representation: "By casting our vote in favor of some party, we subordinate ourselves to power; we hardly do anything ourselves."⁷¹ A bad bhavana, in other words, is fostered in which individuals tend to surrender their svadharma to others. Vinoba's individual karma yoga base thus prompted him to remind us that "Lord Krishna enjoins upon us in the Gita that our deliverance has to be achieved by us only."⁷²

Sarvodaya, therefore, is not a party⁷³ and is "non-partisan in its approach."⁷⁴ As formulated by Vinoba, it is a theory which advises its adherents to "take part in political activities but not in political groupings" since they "must live like lions, not turn into sheep."⁷⁵ While some of his close associates have argued that one can, consistently, remain a "lion" even as a party member⁷⁶ Vinoba remained

⁶⁹Ibid., p. 27.

⁷⁰Ibid., p. 29.

⁷¹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 24.

⁷²Ibid.

⁷³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

⁷⁴Dasgupta, A Great Society of Small Communities, p. 11.

⁷⁵Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 69.

⁷⁶See Archarya Kripalani and Gora in Tandon's Sarvodaya After Gandhi, p. 172.
www.vinoba.in

steadfast in his position. To really understand the reason for this, we shall see, requires an analysis concerning his opinion that "power tends to corrupt."⁷⁷

While he admitted that "there are some great souls who can keep their detachment even while holding a place of authority"⁷⁸ Vinoba held that, in general, the temptations of office are such as to corrupt most people.⁷⁹ The tendency, according to Vinoba, is for the office holder or the party leader to "become narrow in outlook"⁸⁰ as he or she becomes enamoured of the power position. This fosters the rajasic element in one's nature and, hence, one's ego, thereby serving to impede the destruction of the same. According to Vinoba

The problem lies at the very nature of authority⁸¹ . . . (since) in general, the field of government⁸² is not a field of sacrifice. It does not afford natural opportunities for renunciation.⁸³

The primary function of developing "the power of the people" was not, in this context, capturing political power so much as dispersing it. Such decentralization of government allows for more citizen participation and, thereby, the devel-

⁷⁷Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 102.

⁷⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 53. (Probably, this is an allusion to Gandhi.)

⁷⁹Vinoba, as viewed by Noshir Bilpodiwala, The Social Order and Sarvodaya (Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1963), p. 81.

⁸⁰Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, pp. 57-58.

⁸¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 138.

⁸²Here "government" should be understood as "centralized government" as in "representative democracy."

⁸³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 51.

opment of "the strength of the people." As the karma yogin undertakes action in a bhavana of bhakti (dedicating all fruits to God = Society), individual spiritual strength or swaraj is achieved. Correspondingly, the greater the detached service of individuals, freed of bargaining, the more is the collective swaraj made manifest. Thus, Vinoba observed how

The politics of power is one thing while that of strength is another. People generally go after "power politics" but power cramps strength which increases with detached service.⁸⁴

Vinoba's prescription to "never accept political power"⁸⁵ follows, I believe, quite logically from his critical appraisals of the nature of coercive authority in general, of "representative democracy" in particular, and of the extreme tendency of power to corrupt the power-holder. However, just as one should not become enmeshed in attachment to one's body, family or State, for spiritual reasons, one must, nevertheless, participate actively in the society, as a karma yogin. The machinery of the State is destroyed,⁸⁶ therefore, as it is decentralized and

The greater the number of functions taken up by the people from the government, the more non-violence will flourish and the more smooth will be the process of the withering away of the state authority.⁸⁷

Significantly, Vinoba agreed with Marx that the State,

⁸⁴Vinoba, Elections and Democracy, p. 17.

⁸⁵Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 8.

⁸⁶Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 226.

⁸⁷Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 36.

in any centralized administrative⁸⁸ or coercive sense,⁸⁹ will "wither away." This meant, for Vinoba, that "there will be no State authority towards the end" and "the governance of the country will go on without the interference or function of any central power."⁹⁰ Such diminution in the power of the State is, however, by no means inevitable: Ramrajya is no certainty. For the "withering away" to progress requires a development of swatantra loka shakti giving rise to "lok niti" (moral rule by the people)⁹¹ and hence individual effort and purification. Thus, in Vinoba's view

It is only when a large group of people . . . aloof from positions of political power, but . . . endowed with the power of discretion and devoted in every way to service, sacrifice and study is formed on a permanent basis that the task of purifying . . . would be accomplished.⁹²

On the other hand, Vinoba maintained that until the "people's power" (or "strength of the people") is sufficiently developed, the society needs a State and the State ought not to be directly attacked.⁹³ Indeed, "The right form of government depends upon the stage of development reached by

⁸⁸Vinoba, quoted by Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 19.

⁸⁹"Society will reach such a stage . . . as would eliminate the necessity to run a government based on coercion or the power to punish."—Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 137.

⁹⁰Vinoba Bhawe, Sarvodaya and Communism (Tanjore: Sarvodaya Paracharalaya, 1957), p. 19.

⁹¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 15.

⁹²Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 2.

⁹³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 209.

people."⁹⁴ Such a position, however, is not to say that the best form is not signified in the ideal of Ramrajya. Vinoba, after all, continued to observe that we should not allow ourselves "to be governed at all, even by a good government."⁹⁵ It just goes to show that Vinoba realized how

We have got to remember that although our present political system may not be a genuine government by the people, it is certainly government by the consent of the people. To change it we must change the people. . . .⁹⁶

While Vinoba never explicitly defined what is meant by "good government" as an intermediate stage between centralized government and freedom from government,⁹⁷ he did mention that in it the masses give their consent to be ruled by "capable individuals."⁹⁸ Considerable confusion and, I believe, genuine inconsistency was promoted by Vinoba at this point.

On the one hand, Vinoba sometimes implied that his "capable individuals" are the Sarvodaya movement's karma yogins who agree that "The politics of today . . . will change only when the people change."⁹⁹ These workers would be "capable" by virtue of their own spiritual attainments and would, consistently, have authority only in proportion as the masses love them for their services. They would endeavor, through their

⁹⁴Ibid., p. 24.

⁹⁵Ibid., pp. 12-13.

⁹⁶Ibid., p. 57.

⁹⁷Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 65. (See also Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 25.)

⁹⁸Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 47.

⁹⁹Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 18.

actions, to teach by example the message they would have the masses embrace. This message of Sarvodaya would have all proclaim that

I live in the village and that village is an integral part of the world. God is our ruler and we, of the village, run our village-state by mutual consent and cooperative effort.¹⁰⁰

Such workers would promote individual swaraj even as they would avoid the corruptive temptation of wielding power over others. Renouncing all personal advantages these karma yogins would thus avoid all partisanship in their search for Truth. Indeed,

They (would) identify themselves neither with the government nor with the people. They should be independent of both, and render true service to both, by pointing out the virtues and faults of both sides, being friends of all but members of no party.¹⁰¹

On the other hand, Vinoba held that "to disclaim the authorship of all action is superior to capability,"¹⁰² thus strongly implying that his "capable individuals" are not the karma yogins of the movement. Instead of standing "in between the rulers and the ruled"¹⁰³ they would seem to stand as the rulers of the state whose objective may be "to see that every villager is his own ruler."¹⁰⁴ To say, in this context,

¹⁰⁰Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 38.

¹⁰¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 207.

¹⁰²Vinoba, Random Reflections, p. 7 (underline is mine).

¹⁰³Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 3.

¹⁰⁴Vinoba, www.vinoba.in Swaraj Sastra p. 60.

that a "capable individual" becomes capable only "by mutual assistance"¹⁰⁵ and has "authority only to serve the people"¹⁰⁶ would appear to be but a feeble camouflage for an elitist rationale for change.

Such an impression is reinforced by Vinoba's observation that even if Government takes the form of "rule by one," still "if it is based on non-violence it should in reality be regarded as 'rule by all'"¹⁰⁷ Since "There are only individuals who are more or less capable,"¹⁰⁸ (except perhaps, for a small though growing number of true karma yogins) the burden of raising the consciousness of the masses falls heavily upon those who are "capable" in any "good government" stage of development. Indeed, Vinoba observed how

Those without education, without money, without land . . . cannot be expected to think about democracy. Hence this responsibility falls on . . . those who own land and wealth.¹⁰⁹

The initial picture of confusion, therefore, eventually yields to clear inconsistency. Particularly in Swaraj Sastra Vinoba revealed that by "capable individuals", he meant, not the karma yogins who have renounced wealth and land, but the physically strong, the wealthy and the privileged.¹¹⁰ Such people, attached to their possessions and hardly expected to proceed forth in a bhavana of bhakti, would seem incapable of

¹⁰⁵Ibid., p. 55.

¹⁰⁶Ibid., p. 56

¹⁰⁷Ibid., p. 27.

¹⁰⁸Ibid., p. 23.

¹⁰⁹Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 17.

¹¹⁰Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 47.

Vinoba is ~~not~~ just noting the reality
not propounding rule by the capable

teaching swaraj to others. Indeed, within Vinoba's framework, they cannot even approach swaraj for themselves!

To say that "When we aim at freedom from government, we shall at least attain good government"¹¹¹ is no escape from the dilemma since, as has been pointed out, Vinoba believed the former to be an historical possibility. If the principle of representation must, as we have seen, be denounced as a means incapable of attaining to the ideal of Ramrajya so also must a theory of "capable individuals" be dismissed. After all, the Law of Karma tells us that "we reap what we sow,"¹¹² centralization leads to centralization, and capable individuals give rise to others attached to the bhavana of "I am the body." To depend upon "capable" individuals would, in this analysis, be little different from dependence upon "capable" representatives.

Within Vinoba's framework even the occasional exception to the rule that power corrupts must be a karma yogin who believes in fostering individual swaraj in others. Such a person "will not use the government to change the people" but "will use the people to change the government."¹¹³ By his own analysis, however, Vinoba would seem to indicate that other individuals, not so detached, would (however "capable" they might be) almost invariably be corrupted by power. Such people would, in the least, predictably seek to have State policy force the masses to be free.¹¹⁴

¹¹¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 28.

¹¹²Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, p. 27.

¹¹³Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 50.

¹¹⁴Again, here is a slip into a Rousseauian principle: quite contrary to Vinoba's anti-elitist framework.

To his credit, however, Vinoba did observe that "in a good State non-cooperation and resistance are occasional and depend on time and place."¹¹⁵ Indeed, sometimes he went so far as to say that "Sin should be resisted wherever it appears"¹¹⁶ even, presumably, when manifested in a "capable individual." Such resistance, it might be surmised, could be led by those karma yogins of the Sarvodaya movement who, as superior to considerations of capability, would simultaneously teach the masses that

State-power and self-government are two different things. Power can be seized through violence. But self-government is impossible to be achieved without non-violence.¹¹⁷

Through non-violent resistance, or satyagraha, Vinoba hoped to insure that the "good government" might "be so conducted as to leave the road open"¹¹⁸ to progressive decentralization.

Here, at least, Vinoba remained consistently opposed to any "dictatorship of the proletariat" conception during the intermediate, "good government" stage. He observed, accordingly, that "Decentralization of the power of the State should begin even now"¹¹⁹ arguing that "If the goodness in

¹¹⁵Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, p. 65. (Note: There is, however, some confusion even on this point. See Tikekar, Integral Revolution, pp. 42, 132-133.)

¹¹⁶Vinoba Bhave, Christ, the Love Incarnate (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1964), p. 34.

¹¹⁷Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 44.

¹¹⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 26.

¹¹⁹Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 20.

man is not relied upon, the State will never wither away at any time."¹²⁰ Means must be consistent with ends for the means are but the ends in embryo.

At this point it would be well to remember that the power of the State is exhibited in "the coercive power of law" (danda shakti).¹²¹ With regard to this power Vinoba expressed an antipathy similar to his dislike for the state as such. He told us, for example, that appropriation and redistribution of land by law fails, from a sarvodaya standpoint, to "unite the landholder's hearts" but rather "law tears them asunder."¹²² Because law is thus divisive and since, like the State's actions generally, it promotes a bhavana of separation and of being ruled, Vinoba concluded that "Legislation should not be forced on people."¹²³ It would appear, therefore, to be as logically an impure means of producing lok niti as centralization of power is for an end of decentralization.

At this point, however, there arises an inconsistency with regard to danda shakti to parallel that of his "capable individuals" doctrine. While, on the one hand, Vinoba proclaimed that "We must realize that to accept government aid will weaken our vigour, understanding and strength,"¹²⁴ on the

¹²⁰Ibid., p. 19.

¹²¹Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 104.

¹²²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 36.

¹²³Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 21.

¹²⁴Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 53.

other hand he was so "anxious to provide a base to constructive work" as to allow it to "be supplied either by official legislation or by public approval."¹²⁵ He went on to say that

Legislation may be of violent or non-violent nature and it may tilt towards either. If a legislative measure, even if it has the backing of the electorate, is not of a non-violent nature, that legislation itself will be violence.¹²⁶

I fail to see how any legislation, unless adopted by unanimous consent or unless devoid of punitive provisions, could qualify as being of a "non-violent" nature given Vinoba's framework. Such legislation, whether accomplished by a minority or a majority of the population would in either case be as much an example of "brute force" to those opposed as majority rule was argued by Vinoba to be for a minority. To say, moreover, that legislation is "non-violent" if it reflects or is supported by "the power of the people"¹²⁷ sounds like someone claiming a Rousseauian right to utilize a "general will" to force people to be free.

That such an elitist approach is contrary to the sarvodaya ideal of individual karma yogins attaining to swaraj is obvious. As was discussed earlier, such swaraj excludes both being ruled by external forces and seeking to rule over others. The elitism of the devotee of God (in Society) consists in his/her obligation to perform svadharma, and lead, so to speak, by example. The bhavana of bhakti necessarily precludes, in Vinoba's framework, any resorting to questionable

¹²⁵Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 30. (underlines are mine)

¹²⁶Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, p. 31.

¹²⁷Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 31.

means in building the collective swaraj or swatantra loka shakti of the masses.

Vinoba did, however, qualify his sanction of the use of law by observing that

If a particular reform is voluntarily adopted by a number of individuals and if that voluntary action prepares the public mind for the change, then whatever little work is left to be done could be achieved through the process of law.¹²⁸

While non-coercive change is to be most relied upon, it is still evident that brute force is countenanced to finish "whatever little work is left to be done." Like Gandhi,¹²⁹ therefore, Vinoba believed that "the place for legislation . . . comes last."¹³⁰ This would seem to obviate any severe departure from principle as might occur if legislation were utilized as a primary means of bringing about change.

Vinoba's departures, in practice, from the ideal of non-violence, may be better understood by examining his statement that "The uses of the law are not for the morally good or for the morally bad, but for the morally weak."¹³¹ These "morally weak" persons are conscious that physical violence is undesirable and have thus evolved beyond the mentality of the "morally bad." Still, they have not attained the consciousness of "moral goodness" which, in the freedom from government

¹²⁸Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 39.

¹²⁹See Michael Johnson, "Gandhi and King on Jesus and the Use of Legislation as a Means of Producing Change," First Year Research Paper, 1973, esp. pp. 65-67.

¹³⁰Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 39.

¹³¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 164.

stage of Ramrajya, renounces all coercion. In short, the "morally weak" are those who, in the intermediate stages of "good government," need the State and insist upon using laws because they are "ignorant of the power of the soul."¹³²

Vinoba realized that the kinds of service done for the people by the State through laws are "not the kind of service which may be conducive to creating the conditions which will do away with the use of law."¹³³ As he indicated in his critique of the State and of representative democracy, to accept another's authority over one is to perpetuate that authority. Legislation and the actions of "capable individuals" might, it is true, lay a material foundation which, satisfying the needs of the body, may help the bhavana of "I am the body," to be overcome. True spiritual salvation, however, as we have repeatedly seen, could only be attained to by individual karma yogins seeking swaraj by performance of svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti.

While it is, therefore, "the character of the people and not the particular system in which they are bound together that guarantees justice"¹³⁴ that "character" is, nevertheless, a function of how decentralized the power of the State has become. The greater the decentralization, according to Vinoba, the greater the participation of the masses and, through participation, the more their swaraj grows. True democracy in small units and without representatives, parties or voting, becomes, in this context, not merely a means, but also an

¹³²Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, p. 36.

¹³³Ibid., p. 87.

¹³⁴Vinoba, swaraj sastra, p. 61.

end: "the end being the self-development of individuals."¹³⁵

In discussing democracy, therefore, Vinoba concluded by observing how "Today 'cracy' is strong while 'demos' is weak."¹³⁶ "Cracy," represented by institutions of representation (centralization) and such utilitarian instruments as elections and majority rule have become impediments in the fight to overcome the bhavana that "I am the body." Indeed, according to Vinoba, representative democracy "is committing suicide everywhere and the only remedy is to bring lok niti into being."¹³⁷ The suicide, while spiritual in the sense that the people have become slaves (in their attitude) to the representatives,¹³⁸ is also political in the sense that an elite can, in the egoistic interest engendered by virtue of their power, exploit others for their own ends.

Representative democracy is, in this analysis, held to be contrary to the development of each person as a spiritual being. That Vinoba muddled the clarity of this position by inconsistently alluding to doctrines of "capable individuals" and of "non-violent laws" in the intermediate stages of "good government" does not detract from his main line of reasoning. Swatantra loka shakti develops as individuals acting and interacting in society come to realize progressively greater self-rule (swaraj). As the rule of niti (the moral law) evolves into existence through the efforts of karma yogins performing svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti, the ideal of Ram-rajya was thought to become more and more concrete in its being.

¹³⁵Ostergaad and Currell, The Gentle Anarchists, p. 205.

¹³⁶Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 11.

¹³⁷Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 55.

¹³⁸"The situation is that the master himself has become a
 www.vinoba.in
 slave to the servant." Vinoba, Election and Democracy, p. 23.

CHAPTER THREE

CONCLUSIONS

In 1972, when I had the brief opportunity to interview Vinoba Bhave at his ashram, I knew little of the intricacies of his thought. I had been informed, by friends, of his close association with Gandhi and about the key role he had played in the Bhoodan and Gramdan Movements. With a respect somewhat tinged with ignorance, therefore, I sat before the old man in the loincloth and wondered what I might intelligently ask. I resolved to confine myself to several questions I had formulated earlier, one of which was: "Do you agree with Gandhi that 'That government is best which governs least?'" He responded by saying:

No. The best government is that which governs not at all.¹

This reply, it should now be clear, cannot be fully understood except in the light of Vinoba's roots in the idealistic tradition of the Vedanta.² It is out of his "beloved Vedanta"³

¹Vinoba Bhave, quoted by Michael Johnson, My Journal, January 8, 1972.

²"Vedanta connotes . . . final unitive glimpse of reality in which all possible conflicts of diversity are welded into one whole." Vinoba Bhave, quoted by Suresh Ram, Vinoba and His Mission (Kashi: Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962), p. 106.

³Vinoba Bhave, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship (Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962), p. 81.

that Vinoba drew the monism so clearly apparent in the "common good of all" approach of Sarvodaya. From this assumption Vinoba logically concluded that the very idea of opposition is wrong and, hence, that even utilitarian perspectives of conflicts of interests between individuals or between the individual and society are illusory. Such perspectives, including the class notions of Marx, fail to realize that there is an unchanging and common good in all in moksha: the self-realization involving the recognition of the same Atman in all that lives.⁴

Perhaps the key term in this context, is bhavana (attitude). As has been described, - one must attain freedom from the bhavana of "I am the body" in order to transcend the gunas and one's sense of separateness. This spiritual swaraj takes on political connotations as Vinoba admitted that, through socialization, one is taught the false bhavana and that this teaching process is perpetuated through dependence upon the State even as embodied in "representatives." It is the consensus of values in a society, therefore, which must be changed in order to promote the bhavana of "I am the Self" in the mind of everyone.

⁴This may be termed the "mystical tinge" in Vinoba's thought. Atman = Truth = Parma Samya = Ultimate Reality. See Indu Tikekar, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970), pp. 124-125.

The status quo consensus should be confronted obliquely by karma yogins performing their svadharma in a bhavana of bhakti. Refusing to allow others to do their duty of service for them, these individuals should devote themselves to serving God (in Society) eschewing power as a corrupting influence. In a sense, these sarvodaya workers constitute the "iskra,"⁵ or sparks which may forge out a new order. Promoting their own swaraj by their activity they encourage others to live similarly, by their example. Like Vinoba they announce that "We aim at creating a kingdom of kindness"⁶ represented in the ideal of Ramrajya where the growth of niti (the moral law) renders all appeals to coercion unnecessary.

Government, in the end, "governs not at all" for the people as a whole will have, individually, so attained to swaraj (or self rule) as to make the State "wither away." The Vedantic Sarvodaya truth that "All men belong to one human family"⁷ will be realized and "the paternal authority of God" will be recognized and respected.⁸ Progressive decentralization of the power of the State will have allowed a participatory democracy to give full vent to the potential of the karma yogin in every individual thus promoting a merger of individual swaraj into collective swaraj. In this way, Vinoba created a coherent theory in which

⁵"Iskra" is the term used by Lenin to describe the elite cadre, the "sparks" of the revolution.

⁶Vinoba Bhave, Bhoodan Yajna (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953), p. 88.

⁷Vinoba, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 250.

⁸Vinoba Bhave, Revolutionary Sarvodaya (Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964), p. 54.

Society is freed from exploitation when relationships are no longer motivated by bargaining but by a sense of kinship. Society is freed from government when the spirit of human fellowship, rather than that of constitutional and legal relationships, controls social life.⁹

In spite of his steadfast adherence to the Law of Karma, which thus precluded any doctrine that "the means justify the ends", Vinoba's approach may clearly be seen as a threat to the existing order. He saw, for example, that as a first step towards a spiritual revolution in society, the material needs of the poor must be met. But this is not all, for just as the problem of the landless cultivator is overcome the next step is engaged in which "there should be no landowner."¹⁰ Vinoba honestly observed that "I am certainly out to create discontent"¹¹ for he was conscious that the status quo would not support him when it realized that his ultimate economic goal was "From each according to his ability to each according to his need"¹². After all, this would involve an abolition of private property.¹³

Nevertheless, while the eminent Indian Communist leader E. M. S. Namboodripad admits that Vinoba's approach is "as

⁹Dada Dharmadhikari, in Introduction to Democratic Values, pp. vii-viii.

¹⁰Vinoba Bhawe, quoted by Joan V. Bondurant and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society (Berkeley: University of California, 1956), p. 65.

¹¹Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 150.

¹²Vinoba Bhawe, Swaraj Sastra (Kashi: Sarva Seva Snagh Prakashan, 1959), p. 75.

¹³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 418, 173 etc. www.vinoba.in

revolutionary as any socialist or communist would have"¹⁴ he holds that it has severe limitations. First, he agrees with Adi H. Doctor that Sarvodaya "can have little attraction for the atheist"¹⁵ due to its emphasis on God. For all his use of orthodox terminology, however, Vinoba explicitly held that "God manifests himself both in the astika (theist) and in the nastika (atheist)."¹⁶ Describing the "cardinal religion of man" as "Humaneness,"¹⁷ Vinoba emphasized that

The only thing that is a must for a Sarvodaya worker is that he (or she) believe in the indivisible and harmonious character of human good and in the non-violent means to attain it.¹⁸

It must, however, be granted that to require a belief in a "common good" and in the Law of Karma would certainly limit the appeal of any movement today. The paucity of volunteers, even in India,¹⁹ however, cannot be a conclusive criterion with which to pass judgment upon the potential of the sarvodaya approach. After all, Vinoba hardly predicted that the masses of the people, taught for centuries that a willingness to act

¹⁴E. M. S. Namboodripad, quoted by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 74.

¹⁵Adi H. Doctor, Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study (London: Asia Publishing House, 1967), p. 169.

¹⁶Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 170.

¹⁷Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 34.

¹⁸Vinoba, paraphrased by Tikekar, Integral Revolution, p. 147.

¹⁹See, for details, Geoffrey Ostergaard and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists (London: Oxford University Press, 1971).

violently is the only viable means of self-defense, would be converted wholesale to the alternative of nonretaliation.

Indeed, Namboodripad and Doctor reflect the poor understanding, which most people cherish, in their second major criticism: "Self sacrifice is surely anti-biological."²⁰ While I have pursued a study of Satyagraha elsewhere²¹ it should be sufficient to observe that even a good soldier must be willing to die for the "self-preservation" of society. There is no guarantee of individual survival regardless of the approach to action used, although, from a psychological viewpoint, many experts agree that a non-violent approach may even be preferable.²²

A crucial obstacle to the promotion of radical change by any means is fear. Vinoba's sarvodaya approach of attaining swaraj through doing one's duty in an attitude of love successfully provides a context within which individuals may overcome fear. While, in the case of the theist this may involve adherence to a faith in a Day of Judgment or in reincarnation, the realization of "I am the Self" for the atheist may involve a this-worldly devotion to the community or to an ethical standard. In any case, Vinoba's doctrine of swaraj holds that "Those who fear death have ceased to live"²³ because they have ceased to grow in understanding and have

²⁰Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 171.

²¹Michael Sonnleitner, Gandhian Nonviolence: Levels of Satyagraha (New Delhi: Abhinav Publications, 1985).

²²See Jerome Frank, Eric Fromm, Eric Frickson and others.

²³Vinoba Bhave, quoted by George Weller, "Vinoba Bhave: India's Walking Messiah," Yale Review 42: No. 2: December 1952, p. 243.

ceased to act. Undoubtedly, Vinoba would be pleased to hear G. D. H. Cole, the great scholar of Marx, say:

I agree that for us as well as for Indians, Swaraj must be an individual as well as a political experience. It must come to us as something that fills us with a power to deny fear.²⁴

Unlike those Marxists who support a "dictatorship" of the proletariat, Vinoba's approach directs the fearlessness of the individuals to the decentralizing of the State beginning now.²⁵ This utilization of the karma yogin iskra may appear as a conceptual contribution by anyone disillusioned with the progress of the "withering" away of the State in the Soviet Union or elsewhere. In spite of Vinoba's inconsistencies²⁶, the general line of this reasoning led him, as we have seen, even to denounce theories of representative democracy.

At this point, perhaps, it may be admitted that Vinoba's ideal of the Kingdom of God becoming established on Earth may be a bit "utopian."²⁷ Vinoba, himself, seemed to vacillate on this point as, on the one hand, he claimed it is historically possible²⁸ while, on the other, he observed that "virtue lies in taking up only an impossible program."²⁹ But ought

²⁴G. D. G. Cole, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 443.

²⁵See Ostergaard and Currell, The Gentle Anarchists, p. 41.

²⁶i.e., "capable individuals," "non-violent legislation," etc.

²⁷Doctor, Sarvodaya, p. 165.

²⁸Vinoba, Democratic Values, p. 3.

²⁹Vinoba Bhave, Grandan for Gramswaraj (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967), p. 19.

our vacillation be any less than Vinoba's? In pursuing dreams deemed "impossible" by many of their contemporaries, creative people have shown themselves capable of eradicating many diseases from the world, flying to the moon, and so developing weapons' technology as to be able to destroy the world many times over. Ought we to condemn human intelligence as incapable of evolving to new heights? Author Kingsley Martin, at least, would seem to answer in the negative as he wrote how

The mere multiplication of advertised goods, the mere speeding up of communications, the greater efficiency of machinery will benefit no one unless, like Bhave, we learn to think of ourselves as a family sharing, rather than as animals in a jungle in which we prey on each other.³⁰

According to Vinoba "we have already become citizens of the world, science has perforce made us citizens of one world."³¹ Because of rapidly advancing technological capabilities, particularly in the realm of nuclear warfare, he concluded that "We are sitting on the edge of a volcano."³² If his analysis was correct—that the world has shrunk today into an inter-dependent community, and that this community is threatening itself with the practical possibility of annihilation—perhaps the idealism of Vinoba remains realistically important. His approach, at least, provides a hope that "an age is what we make it to be"³³ while, at the same time providing an

³⁰Kingsley Martin, "The Gandhi Way," Atlantic Monthly 206, August, 1960, p. 66.

³¹Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, p. 3.

³²Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, p. 58.

³³Vinoba, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 86.

impetus to manifest the necessary changes beginning now.
Indeed,

I say that both the past and the future are beyond our control. Only the present is in our hands and we must, therefore, endeavor to bring Sat-Yug (the age of Truth) in the present.³⁴

Whether "the human family" is a pre-existent reality which needs to be comprehended, or a myth which is an instrumental necessity for modern survival, is a matter of faith. If, in either case, one agrees with Vinoba that it is an attitude which needs to be brought into the consciousness of the masses, the means to this end might well prove to be crucially important. Certainly, if the Law of Karma is true, "compassion, sharing and sacrifice," in short "nonviolence" will be an instrumental necessity.³⁵ Even if the "how" is not so clear, perhaps the individualist emphasis throughout Vinoba's philosophy will nevertheless seem relevant as it was for Albert Einstein as he wrote:

The only conceivable way of bringing about a reconstruction of our world on new lines is first of all to become new people, ourselves, under the old circumstances.³⁶

³⁴Ibid., p. 200.

³⁵Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement (Nagpur: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973), p. 26.

³⁶Albert Einstein, quoted by Ram, Vinoba and His Mission, p. 474.

APPENDIX I

Below are listed all of the Indian terms and phrases which were used at least once during the course of this paper. All corresponding translations take Vinoba's meaning into account.

acharya	teacher
advaita vedanta	monastic unity of God (Shankara philosophy)
ahimsa	harmlessness, non-violence, love
antyodaya	uplift of the last one
ashram	Karma yogin center for action
astika	theist, one who concentrates on God as external
bhakti	devotion, love
bhakti yoga	the way to God through love
bhavana	attitude, mind-set
bhim	a spiritual Hercules
bhoodan	land-gift
Brahmin	any lofty, exalted person
danda shakti	the coercive power of law
dharma	changing duty (occupation)
gramdan	village-gift
gunas	the qualities of human nature
jnana yoga	the way to God through Knowledge
Karma yoga	the way to God through action (work)

Karma (Law of)	Means/Ends = Seed/Tree
loka shakti	the power of the people
lok niti	the moral rule of the people
mahatma	great soul, saint
moksha	self-realization, salvation
nastika	atheist
niti	moral rule
paramartha	universal good
Parna Samya	Ultimate Reality, Truth
raj	coercive rule of the State
rajas	laziness
raja yoga	the way to God through mental exercises
Ramrajya	the Kingdom of God; collective moksha
rishi	holy man
Samapati sab Raghupati Ki hai:	All wealth belongs to God.
samya yoga	equal reverence for all life
Sarvodaya	the uplift of all, welfare of all, common good
sattva	reason, knowledge
Satya	Truth, God, Atman, Parama Samya
satyagraha	holding firm to truth, non-violent resistance
satyuga	the age of Truth
shakti	power (usually coercive)
svadharma	duty (including both changing and un- changing)
svartha	personal (individual) good
swaraj	self-rule, self-government, freedom, salvation
swatantra-loka shakti	the self-reliant power of the people
tamas	egoistic activity

Tat tvam asi	You are the Self.
vedanta	philosophy of oneness, monism
yajna	sacrifice, suffering
Yatamahi Swarajya	we shall strive to attain this swaraj
yoga	Way of Life
yogin	one who has a way of life

APPENDIX II

Among the key terms in Vinoba's thought are: God, person, society, state and government. While much of this paper has dealt with the interrelationships among these terms, it is possible that the reader may have lost sight of the trees by virtue of the forest. For the purpose of clarifying these terms, therefore, I hope that the following descriptions may be helpful. Let the reader remember, however, that these are my impressions of what Vinoba means by each term:

God

God is the same Atman (Spirit, Soul, Self) which exists in microcosm in all that lives. God is Parama Samya, ultimate reality, and Truth. God is the life-force which informs all matter. God is Love, the self-sacrificing agape, which is the means to the realization of Truth which is itself. (Law of Karma.) God is One.

Person

One is made up of the Self, the Body and his Mind. One who has the unique capacity to reflect with one's mind may identify oneself either more with the Self or more with the body. Insofar as the bhavana (mental attitude) "I am the body" is adopted apparent conflicts of interests emerge between individuals and groups and the realization of the

Self is impeded. Insofar as one has the bhavana of "I am the Self" one has swaraj (self-rule) and is close to God. Complete swaraj, attained through karma yoga practiced with a bhavana of bhakti, is ultimately resultant in moksha (self-realization). True freedom consists in moksha. "Essential" man is God.

Society

Society is both the sum of the individuals composing it as well as a necessary prerequisite for each individual to attain to moksha. The ultimate good of society is the same as that of each of its individuals and is attained insofar as swaraj is reached on their part. Ramrajya (the Kingdom of God) comes to earth as more individuals attain to moksha. As each karma yogin, however, requires other individuals to be of service to and cannot arbitrarily confine svadharma to any particular person or group, the sum of individuals (society) becomes necessary as a prerequisite for the moksha of any. Devotion is thus directed to the Atman in each individual (totalled = society = world).

Government

Government, while composed of individuals, may be thought to have, like each person, a spirit (essential aspect) and a body (peripheral aspect). The essential aspect is, literally, the ideal of literal self-government (swaraj) of each person over oneself (i.e., one's body). The divine government of Ram rajya is "freedom from government" where the moral law of "niti" so rules as to make it seem like no government exists. The peripheral aspect of government is the State.

State

The State is every government to the extent to which it is centralized. It is the "body aspect" of government which breeds conflict and spiritual barriers to the extent it is identified with. The bhavana of "statism" considers it legitimate to allow others to rule over oneself rather than for one to rule over oneself completely. The State, therefore, is diametrically opposed to swaraj and, hence, must be made to "wither away" for all to attain to moksha.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

I. Books

Bhattacharya, Haridas, editor, "'The Religions," The Cultural Heritage of India, Volume IV, Calcutta: The Ramakrishna Mission, 1956.

Bhave, Vinoba, Bhoodan Yajna, Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1953.

Bhave, Vinoba, Christ: The Love Incarnate, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1964.

Bhave, Vinoba, Democratic Values and the Practice of Citizenship, Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1962.

Bhave, Vinoba, Election and Democracy, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967, pp. 17-24.

Bhave, Vinoba, Gramdan for Gramswaraj, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1967.

Bhave, Vinoba, Language Problem, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965.

Bhave, Vinoba, Random Reflections, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1971.

Bhave, Vinoba, Revolutionary Sarvodaya, Bombay: Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, 1964.

Bhave, Vinoba, Sarvodaya and Communism, Tanjore: Sarvodaya Prachuralaya, 1957.

Bhave, Vinoba, Swaraj Sastra, Kashi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1959.

- Bhawe, Vinoba, Talks on the Gita, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970.
- Bilpodiwala, Nashir, The Social Order and Sarvodaya, Varanasi: Bhargava Bhushan Press, 1963.
- Bondurant, Joan V. and Margaret W. Fisher, Indian Approaches to a Socialist Society, Berkeley: University of California, 1956.
- Brecht, Arnold, Political Theory: The Foundations of Twentieth Century Political Thought, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1970.
- Danielou, Alain, Hindu Polytheism, New York: Pantheon Books, 1964.
- Dasgupta, Sugata, A Great Society of Small Communities, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1968.
- Doctor, Adi H., Sarvodaya: A Political and Economic Study, London: Asia Publishing House, 1967.
- Draft Manifesto of the Sarvodaya Movement, Nagpur: Sarva Seva Sangh, 1973.
- Johnson, Michael, My Journal, made possible by the Thomas J. Watson Foundation, Providence, Rhode Island, 1971-1972.
- Mashruwala, K. G., Towards Sarvodaya Order, Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1971.
- New Testament, "Good News for Modern Man," New York: American Bible Society, 1966.
- Ostergaard, Geoffrey and Melville Currell, The Gentle Anarchists, London: Oxford University, 1971.
- Ram, Suresh, Vinoba and His Mission, Kashi: Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh, 1962.
- Sibly, Mulford Q., Political Ideas and Ideologies: A History of Political Thought, New York: Harper & Row, 1958.

Smith, Huston, The Religions of Man, New York: Harper & Row, 1958.

Tandon, Vishwanath, The Social and Political Philosophy of Sarvodaya After Gandhi, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1965.

Tikekar, Indu, Integral Revolution: An Analytical Study of Gandhian Thought, Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 1970.

II. Papers and Articles

Bondurant, Joan V. and Margaret W. Fisher, "Ethics in Action," Australian Journal of Politics and History, XII, 2 (1966), pp. 177-193.

Dean, Vera Micheles, "India: A New Gandhi Walks the Dusty Roads," Reporter 9: October 27, 1953, pp.20-23.

Johnson, Michael, "Gandhian Satyagraha: An Alternative," Whitman College Honors Thesis, 1971.

Johnson, Michael, "Mohandas K. Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr. on 'Jesus and the Use of Legislation as a Means of Producing Change,'" University of Minnesota First Year Research Paper, 1973.

Koestler, Arthur, "Last of the Saints," Commentary 29: February, 1960, pp. 141-149.

Martin, Kingsley, "The Gandhi Way," Atlantic Monthly 206: August, 1960, pp. 63-66.

Rosenthal, A. M., "The Story of a Saint," Coronet 39: January, 1956. pp. 40-45.

Time (four articles): "Communism v. Gandhi's Son," 57: June 4, 1951, p. 36; "The Fifth Son," 58: November 26, 1951, p. 40; "A Man on Foot," 61: May 11, 1953, pp. 32-34; "Bhoodan and Gramdan," 72: December 29, 1958, pp. 20-21.